

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 8 OCTOBER 2026



TWELVE ATTACKS ON TANKERS LAST WEEK. OR NINE. OR SEVEN (P3)

SINGAPORE

Eight officers referred to the police, on a paper six thanked academics say they never worked on

Twelve Desks · One World

THE RABBIT HOLE

Four and a half thousand ground stations registered. Two hundred and ninety-eight of them are awake

THE LONG READ

Laos shut its border to petrol cars — not for the climate, but to stop spending dollars

Source: Associated Press photograph by Amirhosein Khorgooi, via Arab News — commercial vessels at anchor off Bandar Abbas, Iran, 6 October 2026, the day the tanker *On Peace* was struck off Oman. Specific subject; these are the vessels at anchor, not the ship attacked. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE • NO. 126

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The spine: the count — nine desks this morning turn on a number that two careful parties measure differently

FROM THE DESK

“The most important figures that one needs for management are unknown or unknowable, but successful management must nevertheless take account of them.”
Lloyd S. Nelson, quoted by W. Edwards Deming in *Out of the Crisis* (1986)¹
Deming’s own list of deadly diseases included managing by visible figures alone. Today: an unpublished bandwidth, an unenumerated set of conditions, and five counts of one week.

THE STRIP • AT WEDNESDAY’S CLOSE

US 2-year	4.77%	▼ 7bp
US 10-year	5.28%	▲ 1bp
10-year real	2.92%	▲ 1bp
VWRA	\$193.34	▼ 1.15%
DXY	102.27	▲ 0.43%
USD/SGD	1.2791	▲ 0.15%
Brent	\$100.95	▲ 0.37%
Gold	\$4,136.70	▼ 1.20%
Bitcoin	\$83,338	▼ 2.66%

Treasury series at Wednesday’s close; the two funds are London closes, struck before New York. Detail on **p14**. Not advice.²

THE ARCHIVE • THURSDAY — FOUR THINGS THIS MAGAZINE SAID IT WOULD COME BACK TO

No. 125 printed llama.cpp pull request 29887 as open. It merged on 7 October, and the 2.20× held — alongside a net regression on another model (**p8**).

No. 124’s box-office correction is closed. The weekend chart’s “estimates” header is a template; the daily tables flag every row final (**p11**).

Iran’s seven conditions stay unenumerated; the haze is worse, all five regions Unhealthy at five this morning; and the term premium of 1.45 circulating for 1 October is still wrong — the New York Fed’s file says **0.9047** (**p5**, **p14**).³

SOURCES ¹ W. Edwards Deming, *Out of the Crisis* (MIT, 1986), where the observation is credited to Lloyd S. Nelson, then director of statistical methods at the Nashua Corporation. Editions differ between “unknown or unknowable” and “unknown and unknowable”; the former is used here. The line widely attributed to Deming himself — that you cannot manage what you cannot measure — is not his, and he regarded managing by visible figures alone as one of the deadly diseases. ² Levels at the close of Wednesday 7 October 2026, each sourced on **p14**, where the Treasury series are the Department’s own published curves and the real-yield decomposition is this desk’s derivation from two of them. The Straits Times Index closed at 5,608.44, down 1.63%. ³ Each item is checked against the primary source named on the page cross-referenced.

THE WORLD · HORMUZ, DAY TWO HUNDRED AND TWENTY

Twelve attacks last week. Or nine. Or seven

The worst week for tanker strikes since February, on a count nobody shares. Washington calls the strait open, Tehran calls it closed, and both are describing the same ships.

Three maritime security sources told Reuters there were **at least twelve** attacks on tankers around the Strait of Hormuz between 28 September and 5 October, the most of any week since the war opened in February. The International Maritime Organization, counting the same seven days, recorded **nine**. A shipping-intelligence firm said seven; a fourth tally, thirteen.¹

None is lying. The IMO verifies before recording; private trackers log what masters report, including strikes surfacing days later and one that may double-count a listed vessel. That it was the worst week holds under every method. The number does not exist.¹

Not in dispute: the **MT On Peace**, struck on Tuesday nine nautical miles north-east of Lima, in Oman's Musandam. Nineteen crew, seventeen Indian; twelve injured, eleven Indian. India barred its own seafarers from the strait on 16 July. On Wednesday a tanker reported hits **fifty-one nautical miles off Qatar** — deep inside the Gulf, not at the strait. That one rests on a single wire.²

35 ships

THE CORE SHUTTLE FLEET, OF AT LEAST 63 VERY LARGE CRUDE CARRIERS, DOING **THREE-QUARTERS** OF ALL SHUTTLE VOYAGES AND TURNING ROUND EVERY **16 DAYS**³

THE SCEPTIC · THE SHIPS MAY NOT BE TARGETS AT ALL

Marisks told Reuters the incidents “**may not necessarily represent deliberate targeting of individually selected merchant vessels**”, raising the possibility that Iranian forces are firing into a predetermined kill box — which replaces the hunting-tankers reading with something harder to plan around.¹

SOURCES 1 Reuters, 7 October 2026, read at source via Arab News, for the twelve-attack figure attributed to three unnamed maritime security sources, the IMO's count of nine for the same week, the previous high of eight in the week of 13 July, the overlap caveat, and the Marisks remarks. The seven-incident figure is Marisks via Al Jazeera, 6 October; a thirteen-incident count appeared in an independent roundup of the same week. UKMTO's and the IMO's own pages returned HTTP 403 to this desk and were not read. 2 The vessel, position, crew and casualty figures from Reuters, Gulf News and Baird Maritime, all read at source and in agreement; the position and the fire are Oman's Defence Ministry via those reports. The Qatar incident is a single AFP wire of 7 October, read at source; vessel, flag and casualties were not released. India's July order via Baird Maritime. 3 Kpler explainer, data as of 29 September 2026, read at source. 4 Rubio's remarks from an AFP report of his Athens press availability, 7 October, read at source. The Iranian position is Mohammad-Reza Naqdi, adviser to the chief commander of the Revolutionary Guard, in an interview with the state Al-Alam channel, as reported by Xinhua on 7 October and by Press TV the same day, both read at source. The pull quote is Naqdi via Xinhua. 5 Kpler, as above, for the offshore-transfer share, the 60% of regional crude still crossing the strait against 83% pre-war, and the bypass figures; the 18.3m b/d seven-day average and Vortexa's 18.6m from Reuters via NBC, 5 October, read at source; Standard Chartered's “resilience rather than normalization” and the up-to-\$9 offshore discount as carried in a 6 October aggregation of its note. Kpler itself cautions that these flows are estimated, not counted: on 21 September radar showed five tankers loading at Al Basrah with none broadcasting a position. 6 Al Jazeera, 5 October, read at source, for both quoted experts and for the Lloyd's List and sanctions material.

Wednesday produced the war's sharpest pair of sentences. In Athens, Marco Rubio said the strait is open and Iran had “**lost complete control**”. In Tehran, a Revolutionary Guard adviser said it is closed and Iran holds full control.⁴

“Some use small vessels to smuggle oil and transfer it to tankers, even though the strait is closed.”

Against the measurement the two converge. Tehran's explanation for the oil still moving is transfer by small craft, which it calls smuggling; Kpler, counting the same manoeuvre, found **over 70% of August's Hormuz crude changed tankers offshore**. The recovery is a measurement choice too: regional exports hit **18.3m b/d** against roughly 18m pre-war, but crude confirmed crossing the strait is **over 25% below** it, because **40% now goes round**. Standard Chartered's word is “**resilience**”.⁵

THE CHATTER · IS THERE A TOLL, AND CAN ANYONE SHOW IT

Kpler's head of geopolitical risk, Michelle Brohard, suspects a fee is paid for safe passage — perhaps a tenth to a fifth of cargo value — and called it “**just my speculation**”. Abdul Khaliq, of Liverpool John Moores' maritime centre, calls it plausible, then says plainly: “**No public proof confirms a systematic, state-run Iranian toll system.**”⁶

STILL UNENUMERATED

Iran's “**legitimate demands**” were invoked again as the price of reopening — and for the third issue running, **nobody lists them**. Referred to constantly, enumerated nowhere.⁴

FIVE COUNTS

OPEN AND CLOSED

AROUND THE DESKS · FIVE CAPITALS, ONE STRAIT

Everyone agrees the oil moves. Nothing else

Washington reads the flow as defeat for Tehran; Tehran reads it as smuggling it permits. The traders, meanwhile, have stopped arguing and started buying ships.

A week with five casualty counts forces every capital to show its method. The disagreement is not only about blame; it is about what is counted, and where.¹

ATHENS — AFP

Secretary of State **Marco Rubio**, Wednesday: **“The Straits of Hormuz are open. There’s almost as much oil flowing out now as there was before this conflict began. So they’ve lost complete control.”** Sanctions, he added, have left Iran’s economy in “total and complete freefall”.²

TEHRAN — AL-ALAM, VIA XINHUA

Mohammad-Reza Naqdi, adviser to the Revolutionary Guard’s chief commander: the strait is closed and Iran’s forces hold full control; the passages opened by violators **“will soon be closed”**, and will stay shut unless Iran’s legitimate demands are met. Oil still moves, he said, because small vessels smuggle it out to tankers.²

NEW DELHI — MINISTRY OF EXTERNAL AFFAIRS

India called the attacks a matter of **“deep concern”**: **“The targeting of commercial shipping, seafarers and civilian infrastructure in the region must end.”** Eleven of the twelve injured on Tuesday were its nationals.³

The traders have stopped forecasting and started pricing. Tanker fleet utilisation has reached **100%**; spot earnings for a very large crude carrier approached **US\$642,000 a day** in late September. Vitol’s Bahrain managing director, Tom Baker, in Fujairah on Wednesday: **“Today, you can buy a ship and make an immediate return on it.”** His firm now prefers ships to pipelines, because a pipeline takes three years.⁴

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Sustainability, not control. **Tamas Varga** of PVM: the flow holds **“unless attacks on ships and shipping lanes resume.”** **Chris Beauchamp** of IG: **“The shuttle system in the Gulf is doing wonders... but it requires plenty of ships.”** And: **“Ships don’t get built overnight.”**⁵

The producer’s own account sits oddly beside Rubio’s. Aramco’s Amin Nasser told a London forum on Monday that **“the system is already straining”** and **“the supply resilience cushion is scarily thin”** — regional supply down **nearly three billion barrels** in seven months. Then, in the same speech: **“Our system is intact.”**⁶

THE SCEPTIC · TWO HUNDRED MILLION BARRELS, OR ONE HUNDRED

IEA members agreed on Wednesday to accelerate release of the **100m barrels** still outstanding from March’s 400m action, prioritising diesel. The G7 had agreed on 2 October to release **100m barrels** over four months. Nobody has said whether these are the same barrels.⁷

THE CHATTER · THE FRONT THAT OPENED WITHOUT A SHOT

On 5 October the Treasury told foreign banks still dealing with Iran they **“could be targeted at any time without advance notification”**. Four days earlier it had brought Iran’s **automotive and rail sectors** under secondary-sanctions risk for the first time, naming 31 entities.⁸

ALSO IN THE WINDOW

Three killed at two Saudi airports. Houthi attacks killed two women at Abha on Tuesday, injuring 28, and one man at Riyadh’s King Khalid on Wednesday, injuring eight.⁹

100% UTILISATION

\$642K A DAY

BANKS NEXT

SOURCES 1 This desk’s reading of the sources at note 1 on p3. 2 Rubio via an AFP report of his Athens remarks, 7 October, read at source. Naqdi’s interview with the state Al-Alam channel as reported by Xinhua, 7 October 22:57, and by Press TV the same day, both read at source. 3 India’s Ministry of External Affairs as quoted by Reuters, Gulf News and Baird Maritime, 6–7 October, all read at source and in agreement; mea.gov.in returned HTTP 403 and the original statement was not read. 4 The National, 7 October, read at source, reporting Baker at a Fujairah industry forum; the utilisation and VLCC earnings figures are Clarksons Research as cited there. 5 Al Jazeera, 6 October, read at source. 6 The National and the Irish Times, both 5 October and both read at source, reporting Nasser at the Energy Intelligence Forum in London. The “\$200 a barrel without the East-West pipeline” line circulating from the same speech is the reporters’ paraphrase, not a quotation, and is not printed here. 7 The National and Xinhua, both 7 October, read at source, for the IEA members’ statement, the 325m already released of 400m pledged, the remaining ~1.1bn barrels of emergency stocks and Fatih Birol’s quoted readiness to release more; iea.org returned HTTP 403 and its own statement page was not read. The G7 comparison and the analyst doubt are from Reuters as carried in the same reports. 8 OFAC Alert, “Notice to Foreign Financial Institutions Conducting Business with Iran”, 5 October 2026, downloaded and read in full; OFAC Recent Actions, 1 October 2026, for the Executive Order 13902 determination on the automotive and rail sectors and the 31 designations. Both primary. 9 Arab News, 7 October, read at source, for the airport attacks and the air-defence claim. The Yemen ground-war items reached this desk only through two daily aggregators citing AP, Reuters and AFP; the originals were not read and the figures are carried with that caveat.

SINGAPORE · EIGHT OFFICERS, ONE WORKING PAPER

Eight public officers referred to the police

The study behind them thanks six academics who say they had nothing to do with it – and its S\$270 million is what the flats cost, not what anyone made.

Answering ten parliamentary questions together on Tuesday, Chan Chun Sing said the Public Service Division has reviewed **191 officers'** property transactions and referred **eight** to the police – some for the circumstances of the purchase, others because there was too little information to rule them out. He was careful: **“a referral does not mean that wrongdoing has been established.”**¹

What prompted it is a National Bureau of Economic Research working paper, not peer-reviewed, matching property caveats from 1995 to 2019 against six snapshots of the government directory. It finds civil servants buying within a kilometre of a future MRT station at a rate **0.67 percentage points** above matched controls a year before the announcement, and 0.53 points two years before – a relative lift above 60%, with nothing significant at three years or afterwards.²

S\$146,898

THE PAPER'S ESTIMATED EXTRA ANNUAL RETURN ON AN AVERAGE INFORMED PURCHASE OF **S\$1,224,150**, AGAINST THESE OFFICERS' AVERAGE ANNUAL INCOME OF **S\$136,596**. ON ITS OWN ARITHMETIC, ONE FLAT PAID A SECOND SALARY²

THE SCEPTIC · THE ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS, AND THE DENOMINATOR

Six academics thanked in the paper told CNA they were not involved; one said her name appeared by mistake and asked for its removal. Reading the current version on Wednesday, two names are gone and **four remain**. Separately, the excess is about **113 purchases** drawn from **9,347 officer-years** per event year – some **0.6%**. And the S\$270m is **gross purchase value, not gain**.²³

A Singapore critique published in September goes at the inference, not the integrity: the authors never observe an official receiving anything, a directory snapshot does not prove someone held a post on the day of a purchase, and “officially unannounced” is not unknowable – station sites can be inferred from published corridors by people who read plans for a living. Its verdict: **“consistent with information leakage is not the same thing as proof of information leakage.”**³

And a timing problem nobody pressed in the chamber: the paper's own finding is that informed purchases **disappear after the 2011-12 tightening**. On its evidence the conduct is fifteen years old and already fixed. PSD extended its review to 2014 as a precaution; Chan has not said whether anything turned up in those years.¹²

THE CHATTER · THINNER THAN IT LOOKS

Reddit refused this desk at the domain level and HardwareZone returned a 403, so what follows is an indexed summary of one thread, not a read of it: in mid-September, at the review stage, replies ran sceptical. No forum reaction to Tuesday's referrals was found at all.⁴

AND THE AIR GOT WORSE

At five this morning all five regions were Unhealthy for the first time this episode – West **162**, Central **147**, East 128, South 120, North 114. But the one-hour reading in the west moved only 87 to **89**: accumulation, not a fresh surge. Only West and Central sit in the Elevated hourly band. The health ministry told Parliament hospitals can open surge beds, and named no PSI trigger.⁵

Community mental-health referrals rose 14% in a year, 7,795 to 8,884 – and **31%** among 18-to-25s, where the unemployed component went 157 to 658.⁶

0.6% OF OFFICER-YEARS

PSI 162 WEST

SOURCES 1 The Public Service Division's own published reply to Parliamentary Questions 18 to 27, taken together at the sitting of 6 October 2026, read at source, for the 191 reviewed, the eight referred, the two grounds for referral, the extension of the review window to 2014, the declaration regime and the quoted caution. Chan's further remarks that day as reported by AsiaOne and Mothership, both read at source and in agreement. 2 Piskorski, Seru, Zhang and Zhao, “Do Social Norms Substitute for Enforcement? Evidence from Public Officials' Home Purchases in Singapore”, NBER Working Paper 35756, September 2026; the full PDF was downloaded and read. Not peer-reviewed. The coefficients, the 9,347 officer-event observations, the S\$270m gross acquisition value across officers and relatives, the per-transaction value and return figures, and the disappearance of the effect after 2011-12 are all the paper's own. The 0.6% is this desk's arithmetic on its figures. The paper itself describes its estimate as one of *potential access* to non-public information and concedes in a footnote that six directory snapshots may misclassify people who had joined or left the service. 3 The six academics' statements as reported by Mothership citing CNA in September, read at source; the comparison with the acknowledgements in the version of the paper read on 8 October 2026 is this desk's own. No statement was obtained from the authors or from NBER, and the date the acknowledgements changed is not known. The methodological critique and the pull quote are from an unsigned Singapore blog essay of 19 September, read at source and identified here as opinion. 4 An indexed summary of HardwareZone thread 7222958; the forum returned HTTP 403 to a direct request and was not read. Reddit was unreachable. Characterised as a handful of visible replies, not as representative. 5 The National Environment Agency's real-time readings via the government data API, timestamped 05:00 on 8 October 2026 and read at source, with NEA's own banding; the haze situation updates of 7 October for the Sumatra and Kalimantan plumes. The surge-capacity answer is the health ministry's reply to Parliamentary Question 3006, 6 October. Regional hotspot counts remain unobtainable: six routes to the ASEAN centre's figures were tried and all returned errors or client-side shells. 6 Health ministry replies and releases of 6 and 7 October 2026, read at source; the totals are this desk's arithmetic on the published table.

THE ATELIER • FORGED AGAINST STAMPED

The number on the box is the one that means least

Eighteen-ten and eighteen-eight are essentially the same steel, says the British industry's own association. The figure that does separate the tiers is printed by almost nobody.

Start with the two numbers on the box: chromium and nickel. The British Stainless Steel Association is blunt about them — 18/10 **“is claimed to indicate a better quality steel than ‘18/8’, and is essentially the same as the ‘304’ grade.”** Two points of nickel, inside labelling tolerance. Even 18/0 is **“adequate for normal tableware use”**.¹

Then “forged”, which almost never means a forge. Mono, in Mettmann, publishes its sequence: blank at **65 tonnes per square centimetre**, roll the bowl end thinner in **16 to 30 passes** while the handle keeps its section, punch the tines, emboss at **600 to 800 tonnes**. No hammer, no anvil, no heat. Studio William uses the honest term for forks and spoons — **cold forged** — and keeps hot forging for blades. That selective rolling is the real difference: a stamped piece is punched from sheet of one thickness, so its handle can never exceed it.²

Above the floor you buy hand-work: Yamazaki of Tsubame counts **35 processes, or 50 for special designs**, against the **ten** it says cheap cutlery takes.³ What scales with money is published by almost nobody. Robert Welch names two gauges: **Collection 3.5** at 3.5mm, a place setting from **£34**; **Collection 5.0** at 5.0mm, from **£50**. A millimetre and a half of handle stock is the category's only numbered upgrade. Above it, Mellor's Pride runs **£135** in stainless, **£217** in plate, **£2,250** in sterling.⁴

THE CHATTER • WHO ACTUALLY MADE IT

The name on the box is often not the workshop. Sori Yanagi flatware is **made by Nihon Yōshokki in Tsubame**, as Japan House London states plainly. David Mellor prints that its Embassy sterling is **“made for us... by specialist Sheffield maker Fletcher Robinson”**. And seven national-sounding brands — Richardson Sheffield, Couzon, Lou Laguiole — are siblings in one Dutch group.⁵

THE SCEPTIC • THREE PLACES THE MONEY GOES NOWHERE

Coatings: one house's PVD sets run **S\$797–1,583** here against **S\$291** uncoated, for a film that cannot be re-polished. **Licensing:** Arthur Price sells a 44-piece canteen at **£395** in one range and **£955** in another, same catalogue. **Geography:** Robert Welch publishes alloy, blade steel, gauge and every length — never the country. And a 157-piece Georg Jensen Acorn service took **US\$6,000** at auction in 2024, about **US\$38 a piece**, against **£330** for one new fork.⁶

Singapore: ToTT lists Sambonet 18/10 at **S\$189–307**, mostly out of stock. Robert Welch ships free above **£150**, duties at checkout. Humidity is a non-issue for 18/10, a labour cost for silver — and never load both together: Arthur Price warns that mixing them **“will corrode the steel”**, not the silver.⁷

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Carbon-steel & cast-iron pans — spun against sand-cast, and why cheap often wins.

Mattresses & slat bases — latex against pocket springs in the tropics.

Wallets & card cases — four ounces of leather, and the tannery behind it.

5.0MM

COLD FORGED

9% OVER S\$400

SOURCES 1 The British Stainless Steel Association's article on cutlery grades, read at source via an archived capture; the live site returned a bot challenge. Both quotations are its own. 2 Mono (Seibel Designs), Mettmann, production-process page, read at source, for every tonnage, the number of rolling passes and the finished sections; Studio William's own materials page for “cold forged” and for hot-forged knife steel. 3 Yamazaki Kinzoku Kogyo's corporate pages, read at source, for the process counts, the manual-labour share and the 1991 Nobel banquet commission; Studio William and Mono for theirs. 4 Robert Welch's own collection and product pages for both gauges and prices; David Mellor's own pages for Pride in all three metals, the made-to-order lead time and the minimum order. All read at source, in sterling as listed. 5 Japan House London's product page naming the Tsubame manufacturer; David Mellor's Embassy page naming its sterling subcontractor; the Amefa Group's own statement of its seven brands. All read at source. A further claim circulating in the trade press — that Sheffield's remaining volume forger supplies blanks to other flatware companies — could not be opened and is not printed as fact. 6 Singapore prices from the retailer's own listings; Arthur Price's own canteen prices across its two ranges; Robert Welch's site searched for a country of manufacture without result. The auction figure is Cottone Auctions, lot 239, 21 September 2024, read at source: 157 pieces, 159.4 troy ounces, US\$6,000 with premium; the per-piece figure is this desk's division. The new fork price is Georg Jensen's own. 7 Retailer pages and Robert Welch's shipping terms read at source; the import-relief threshold, the per-item rule and the 9% rate from IRAS's own guidance. The tarnish mechanism and its two countermeasures are the Canadian Conservation Institute's; the daily-use remedy is Robbe & Berking's. The pull quote is Arthur Price's own care page.

TECHNOLOGY · THE CHIPS NOBODY BUYS OUTRIGHT

Sixty billion dollars, secured on chips nobody can price

Broadcom supplies the processors, leases them, lends against them and guarantees what they will be worth. Its customer's own prospectus calls that a potential conflict of interest.

The chips have not been bought. They have been borrowed against. On **5 October** Bank of America, Citigroup and Morgan Stanley began syndicating a **US\$60bn** debt package whose proceeds buy Google Ironwood processors, park them in a special-purpose vehicle and lease them to Anthropic, which repays the lenders out of the lease.¹

The senior tranche is **US\$42bn**, rated A-, secured on the hardware and carrying a partial residual-value guarantee from **Broadcom**. The junior **US\$18bn** is led by Blackstone, putting up **US\$9bn** of its own and placing the rest; those holders take the borrower's credit directly.¹

Now count Broadcom's roles. It builds the accelerators. It is a lessor through the vehicle. It has separately extended its customer a convertible facility of up to **US\$42bn** — a different instrument, routinely confused with the senior tranche. And it underwrites what the hardware fetches when the lease ends. Four seats at a table with itself.²

US\$179.2bn

BROADCOM'S REMAINING PERFORMANCE OBLIGATIONS AT **2 AUGUST 2026**, ROUGHLY A QUARTER OF IT DUE AS REVENUE INSIDE TWELVE MONTHS — THE ONE NUMBER ON THIS PAGE READ IN A FILING RATHER THAN IN COVERAGE OF ONE³

THE SCEPTIC · A GUARANTEE ON AN ASSET WITH NO MARKET

Residual-value guarantees work where resale is liquid: aircraft, cars, forklifts. No mature market exists for pricing AI accelerators at this scale, and a TPU is less fungible than a GPU — it runs one vendor's stack.

PGIM has written that doubt into a covenant, capping AI-related collateral at **15%** of a **US\$500m** vehicle; Broadcom's five-year credit default swaps touched a record **122bp** in August.⁴

SOURCES 1 Two independently fetched outlets, read at source: TechTimes, 6 October 2026, and Crypto Briefing, 5 October 2026, both reporting an originating Financial Times story of 5 October that is paywalled and was not read here; the tranche detail is attributed by TechTimes to Bloomberg. The syndication-letter and settled-size caveats are TechTimes'. 2 The convertible facility, the **US\$125.2bn** lease commitment behind it and the "potential conflict of interest" wording are reported from a prospectus this desk could not obtain: four separate EDGAR queries returned no operating-company S-1 for Anthropic, only feeder-fund registrants. Attributed to the outlets at note 1, not to the filing. 3 Broadcom Inc., Form 10-Q for the quarter ended 2 August 2026, filed 10 September 2026, read at source on sec.gov. The document served was truncated before Note 10, where a residual-value guarantee would be disclosed; that note was not read. The company's AI-revenue breakout does not appear in the sections read. 4 PGIM's collateral cap, the Bank of America exposure estimate, the credit-default-swap level and the fungibility argument from TechTimes, read at source, which attributes the analyst remarks to Reuters and to a Cambridge Associates note. 5 The SpaceX financing from a Financial Times headline of 6 October indexed at source; the body is paywalled and unread. Historical analogues as offered in the TechTimes piece. 6 Hacker News item listings read at source, 5–7 October 2026. 7 Raspberry Pi's own price-increase post of 1 October and Engadget's report of 7 October, both read at source; the Tesla memory change from a trade roundup of 5 October. Old board prices are this desk's subtraction, not published figures. 8 DIGITIMES roundup of 5 October, read at source; bis.gov/news-updates was checked directly and its most recent item is 2 October.

"Off-balance-sheet structures can obscure risk."

Nor is it one deal. Inside the same forty-eight hours SpaceX began seeking **US\$40bn**, led by Apollo, to buy Nvidia hardware. One template: the vendor finances the purchase of its own product and books the revenue now. The analogues offered this week were Nortel in 2001 and the collateralised debt obligation in 2008.⁵

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE ENGINEERS DID NOT DISCUSS

There is no forum verdict here, and the silence is the finding. The report of a sixty-billion-dollar deal drew **four points and no comments** on Hacker News the same week a new small language model drew **469 points and 220**. It is being explained to credit desks, not to the people who will run the machines.⁶

One caution about the figure itself. Syndication letters are invitations, not signatures. August reporting put the package near **US\$100bn** before it settled at sixty, and no closing amount exists. Nothing has been raised; something has been offered.¹

ALSO THIS WEEK

Memory was the quiet through-line. Raspberry Pi lifted its 2GB boards **US\$12.50** each on 1 October, Eben Upton calling the old prices "unsustainable"; Tesla halved the AI5's memory **144GB to 72GB**; and Nvidia's DGX Spark, launched at **US\$3,999**, now trades near **US\$7,000** at 128GB — **p9**.⁷

A California executive was arrested over the alleged routing of servers holding some **US\$300m** of Nvidia accelerators to China through Malaysia and Singapore. Single-sourced to one trade outlet; the Bureau of Industry and Security's newsroom carried nothing in the window.⁸

VENDOR FINANCING

A- RATED

NOT YET RAISED

THE HOME LAB · THE CORRECT VERSION IS SLOWER

The right implementation runs eight times slower

A multi-token prediction head merged into llama.cpp on Tuesday. The fast version of it was wrong, and the maintainer said so on the thread.

Pull request 29928 merged into llama.cpp's master branch on 7 October, sixteen of eighteen checks green. It gives the GLM-5-Next architecture a multi-token prediction head: a block that drafts several tokens at once, which the full model verifies in a single batch. Every accepted draft is a decode step that never runs.¹

The appeal is that the drafter lives inside the model — no second checkpoint, no extra weights resident. The NextN block folds the embedded token into the trunk's hidden state, runs one sparse-attention layer and borrows the model's own output head.¹

Then the interesting part. The author's first version ran a "headless" mode skipping work for draft positions that produce no output. **Georgi Gerganov corrected the premise on the thread:** attention must still be computed there, because those positions write cache entries the next step reads. Only the feed-forward can be skipped. The headless path came out on 5 October.¹

6.9 → 2.9ms

THE FOUR-TOKEN CATCH-UP, BEFORE AND AFTER. THE REMOVED, INCORRECT VERSION REACHED **0.33ms** — SO THE IMPLEMENTATION THAT SHIPPED IS ROUGHLY **8.8×** SLOWER AT THAT STEP THAN THE ONE THAT WAS WRONG¹

"Attention must not be skipped for empty outputs — only the feed-forward."

Which leaves throughput, and the numbers need care. The tables show **+17.4%** at 8,192 context on six RTX 3090s and **+16.8%** at 32,768. A community contributor measured them, and they are **not** multi-token-prediction figures: they belong to a sparse-attention commit in the same branch. The harness does not exercise the new head at all. Anyone

quoting seventeen per cent for it has misread the page.¹

THE CHATTER · THE REVIEW THREAD IS THE COMMUNITY

The only genuine throughput claim for the head itself comes from **ServeurpersoCom**, who reports decode roughly doubling at short context on 97% acceptance and **+52% at 32k** — and does not name the card.

aml7an pressed for the optimisation to be split out so its effect could be measured separately, which it never was before merge.¹

THE SCEPTIC · TWO COSTS THE MERGE DID NOT PAY

It breaks image input. After the merge Gerganov reported that multimodal input aborts with the head enabled; the thread closed with a fix suggested and not applied. And the drafting context lives somewhere: **ServeurpersoCom** found it cut his usable window from **128K to 48K** on a one-bit quantisation. You buy decode speed with sixty per cent of your context — on the hardware most likely to want the speed, exactly what is scarce.¹

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT

No. 125 printed pull request 29887 as open. It merged on 7 October, and the headline survived: on an RTX 5090 the host-memory expert cache took decode from **30.8 to 67.8 tokens a second** — **2.20×**, at an 89% hit rate. The rest of the thread is less flattering. On two 5090s running a different model it was **slower than no cache at all**, hitting 47%; on an AMD card at 85% hits it matched a CPU-only run. The gain tracks hit rate, and hit rate tracks how the model routes.²

Low-power inference, for once with the power stated.

Raspberry Pi published figures on 5 October for Qwen3-1.7B on a Pi 5 with an NPU module: **11.60 tokens a second** on the faster part against **4.64** on the slower — a gap the write-up puts down to LPDDR5 against LPDDR4X. About **3W**, stated as NPU and not wall power. Quantisation is never given, and the vendors co-wrote the page.³

MERGED 7 OCT

IMAGE INPUT BROKEN

BANDWIDTH AGAIN

SOURCES 1 github.com/ggml-org/llama.cpp pull request 29928, read at source: merge state, merge commit, check count, approvals, the author's catch-up timings, NenadSteric's benchmark tables and their hardware, ServeurpersoCom's throughput and context-window figures, Gerganov's correction on attention, aml7an's request to split the commit, and the post-merge image-input report. An exact merge time could not be obtained: the GitHub API refused this desk's requests, so the date is printed without a clock. NenadSteric discloses that his tables were tabulated with model assistance; the runs are his. 2 Pull request 29887, read at source, for the merge, Gerganov's approving comment, the author's own RTX 4090 and 5090 figures and cache settings, paulp83's two-card regression and bus measurements, and LeoBorcherding's AMD HIP results. The 2.20× figure was produced with a 19,000 MiB cache; the maintainer's recommended setting is 16,384. Single-device only; multi-GPU support is a later pull request. 3 raspberrypi.com, "Seeing, understanding, and responding", 5 October 2026, read at source. The post does not say who ran the benchmarks and is co-authored with the module vendors; Raspberry Pi is credited with no measurements of its own.

THE KIT · SIX THOUSAND DOLLARS, NO BENCHMARKS

The one specification that decides it is missing

Microsoft opened pre-orders on Tuesday for a desktop built to hold a hundred-and-twenty-billion-parameter model. Five sources, including its own and Nvidia's, publish no memory bandwidth.

The **Surface RTX Spark Dev Box** went to pre-order on 7 October at **US\$5,999**, shipping in November: an Nvidia RTX Spark superchip, 6,144 Blackwell cores beside a twenty-core Grace, **128GB of unified LPDDR5X**, 2TB removable, a hundred-watt envelope and a thousand vents in its lid.¹

The pitch is one sentence on Microsoft's own page: run models beyond 120 billion parameters locally, at up to a petaflop. Its own footnote defines that petaflop as theoretical four-bit performance with sparsity, and concedes the GPU-addressable memory is less than the 128GB headline.¹

For a machine whose whole proposition is holding a very large model in memory, the number that decides whether it works is sustained bandwidth — how fast weights reach the cores. This desk checked five places, including **Nvidia's own RTX Spark page**. None publishes a figure in gigabytes per second. Nor a benchmark: **none of the four** reports of pre-order day read here carried a measured tokens-per-second number, four months after Microsoft's Windows chief declined to give one at the announcement, saying they would come nearer launch.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE HONEST NUMBER CAME FROM MICROSOFT

The most candid figure on the record is Pavan Davuluri's own at Build: this class of device gets to **"about 100 billion parameter model running"** — not the 120 of the marketing — and at a hundred thousand tokens of context **the key-value cache alone can take 40 to 50GB**. A third of the machine, before any weights. The same constraint surfaced independently in a merge queue this week: a drafting cache that cut one developer's usable window from 128K to 48K (p8).³

And the timing is unkind. Nvidia's DGX Spark launched at **US\$3,999** and now changes hands near **US\$7,000** at 128GB — the same squeeze that put Raspberry Pi's 2GB boards up US\$12.50 on 1 October. Buying 128GB of LPDDR5X this month is buying the most inflated component on the board.⁴

THE CHATTER · THERE ISN'T ANY

Nobody owns one; it ships in November. The launch item drew **six points and no comments** on Hacker News. The only extended hands-on with this silicon anywhere is a July forum thread, which returned a 403 and was not read. A six-thousand-dollar machine arrived with no benchmarks, no bandwidth figure and no community.⁵

STILL ON THE SHELF

No Singapore price, and not coming: Microsoft sells it **"exclusively on Microsoft.com in the US."** The **Surface Laptop Ultra**, pre-ordered the same day from US\$2,599, is also unlisted here.¹

Pebble Round 2 is shipping — the first 200 built. The maker's own post is the story: in some sample rounds **"only 15% of cases passed"** quality control, and buyers who cannot live with bugs are told to cancel.⁶

Huawei's FreeBuds Neo now has a Singapore page, a Buy button and no price — a sixth issue held. **Ray-Ban Meta Audio** is still "coming soon" here, with no date and no price.⁷

NO BANDWIDTH PUBLISHED

SOURCES 1 Microsoft's Windows Blogs pre-order post of 7 October 2026 and its own Surface RTX Spark Dev Box product page, both read at source, for the price, ship window, specification, the US-exclusive sales line and the two footnotes qualifying the petaflop and the addressable memory; the core counts are Nvidia's RTX Spark page and Engadget's report of 7 October. Microsoft's Singapore Surface page was checked directly on 7 October: neither machine is listed and the only Singapore-dollar price on it is for an unrelated model. 2 The five pages checked for a bandwidth figure were Microsoft's product page, its launch post, Nvidia's RTX Spark page and two reports of the June announcement; none states one. The benchmark count is of the four reports of pre-order day read by this desk. One of those four discloses that its author is an AI research agent and is not treated here as independent journalism. 3 Pavan Davuluri's remarks at Build as reported by VentureBeat, 2 June 2026, read at source. 4 Engadget, 7 October, read at source, for the DGX Spark comparison; Raspberry Pi's own price post of 1 October for the board increase. 5 Hacker News item listings read at source. The July forum thread on this silicon returned HTTP 403 and was not read; it is named here only as an unopened door. 6 Core Devices' own Pebble blog post of 30 September 2026, read at source. No base price is stated in it. 7 Huawei's Singapore headphones category page and the FreeBuds Neo product page, both read at source on 7 October: specifications but no price, no stock level and no launch date. The cancellation figures are Huawei's own laboratory claims under IEC 60268-24 and are an average with an in-band peak, not a single headline figure. Meta's Singapore glasses page was read the same day; it lists no audio-only model and gives one starting price without saying which product it applies to.

THE GOOD LIFE · A WATCH WITH THREE RATINGS

Seiko's own pages disagree on how wet it can get

A panda-faced chronograph, five thousand pieces, five hundred and ninety euros. The maker lists it as splash resistant, as three bar, and as thirty metres, depending which page you open.

Seiko put a concept into production on Tuesday. The **power design project collection 2** — refs **HHK001** in black and white, **HHK002** in pink — began as a 2024 exhibition piece by the designer Kiyotaka Sakai and now ships in November at **€590**, or **US\$540** on Seiko's American page.¹

It is a joke executed with unusual care. The dial is brushed to look like panda fur; the two chronograph registers are the eyes; the hands are bamboo leaves; the caseback is shaped like a tail. The tachymeter has been renamed the **SASAMETER** and recalibrated to a top of **30 km/h**, which is roughly as fast as a panda goes.¹

Then the specification, which is where the thing gets interesting. Calibre **8T61**, a quartz chronograph good to ± 15 seconds a month on a three-year battery. **43mm** across and **14.6mm** thick — substantial for quartz. Crystal is **Hardlex**, not sapphire. The caseback snaps on rather than screwing down.¹

3,000 + 2,000

THE TWO EDITIONS: THREE THOUSAND OF THE BLACK-AND-WHITE HHK001, TWO THOUSAND OF THE PINK HHK002. A FIVE-THOUSAND-PIECE RUN ON A SINGLE VISUAL JOKE¹

THE SCEPTIC · WHICH RATING WOULD YOU TRUST IT TO

Seiko's own global, American and Singapore product pages all say only "**Splash resistant**". Seiko's press release for the same watch says **3 bar**. Two specialist titles that handled it print **30 metres**, and one notes the caseback itself is engraved merely "water resistant", with no depth at all. Three figures and a blank, from one maker, about one object, in one week. The practical answer is to keep it dry; the interesting part is that the maker has not settled on an answer either.¹²

"Every once in a while, Seiko releases something that makes me wonder how it survived all the meetings."

THE CHATTER · DELIGHT AT THE IDEA, A SHRUG AT THE SHEET

The collector read divides cleanly. On one enthusiast site a commenter calls the price "**astonishingly**" low for the work in it and wonders whether it is a loss-leader or a misprint; another predicts "**the flippers will be all over it**", and notes the maker's own link has no buy button. A specialist editor who likes it still asks the obvious: "**why not a high-end 'panda' chronograph?**" Nobody read by this desk called it overpriced. Reddit and the big watch forum were both unreachable, so this is three comment sections, not a community.²

IN BRIEF

No Singapore price. The Seiko Singapore page for the HHK001 exists, lists it as a new limited edition of 3,000 for November — and carries no figure in dollars. Nothing is converted here.¹

Roger Dubuis put twelve knights on a dial — Excalibur Knights of the Round Table "Metamorph Merlin", pink gold, 45mm, **28 pieces**, price on request. Toledano & Chan showed a one-off titanium "**Oshinobi**", its sliding cover hiding some 387 diamonds; it goes to a New York benefit auction on 5 December.³

And a Japanese hi-fi house went black. Esoteric's limited Black Editions of the F-01 and F-02 amplifiers carry **no price on the maker's own pages**; one American title puts them at US\$21,000 each.⁵

October's auction results are still not printable. The New York online sale was reported as closing on the 9th and the house's own results page returned a 403 to this desk. Geneva runs 27 October to 10 November; Hong Kong on 21–22 November. Nothing is quoted here until a hammer price can be read at the house.⁴

€590

HARDLEX

THREE RATINGS

SOURCES 1 Seiko Watch Corporation's press release of 6 October 2026 and its own global, United States and Singapore product pages for references HHK001 and HHK002, all read at source, for the designer, the movement, dimensions, crystal, caseback, edition sizes, the renamed bezel scale and its 30 km/h calibration, the European and American prices, the November availability and the absence of a Singapore price. The conflicting water-resistance statements are taken from those pages and that release as they stood on 7 October 2026. The nickname by which the watch is widely known appears neither on the dial nor in the release and is not used as its name here. 2 Two specialist watch titles' hands-on reports of 6 and 7 October 2026, read at source, for the 30-metre figure, the caseback engraving, the quoted editorial lines and the named reader comments. The pull quote is from the 6 October report. Reddit and the principal watch forum refused automated access, so no community consensus is characterised. 3 Both from a specialist title's introductions of 5 and 6 October 2026, read at source. 4 Checked on 7 October 2026: the auction house's own results page returned HTTP 403 and the sale had not closed. Sale dates are secondary. 5 Esoteric's own news item of 30 September 2026 and its product pages for the F-01 and F-02 Black Editions, read at source: no price is published on any of them. The US\$21,000 figure is a single American title's hi-fi roundup of 1 October and is carried as that outlet's figure, not the maker's.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE AUDIENCE THAT LIKED IT

Seventy-three per cent, from almost nobody

The people who paid for this weekend's *Iñárritu* picture rated it twenty-one points above the critics. Its Saturday takings fell below its Friday, which is not a thing word of mouth does.

Alejandro G. Iñárritu's *Digger*, with Tom Cruise as an ageing oil tycoon, opened on **3,321** screens on 2 October and took **US\$8,001,856** across its first weekend. That figure is an actual, not an estimate — the daily rows on the tracking service are flagged as final.¹

Inside the weekend is the number that matters. Friday took **\$3,487,210**. Saturday took **\$2,667,767** — **down 23.5%**. A film people are telling each other about goes up on Saturday. Sunday fell another 30.8%, Monday another 58.5%. Through Tuesday the domestic total was **\$9,916,375**, with **80.7%** of it banked in those first three days against a production budget of **US\$125m**.¹

The reception split further than usual. Critics gave it **52%** across 287 reviews and a Metascore of **46** from 58. Audiences gave it **73%** from a thousand-plus verified ratings. A twenty-one-point gap — except the audience sample is the small, self-selected group who turned up anyway.²

-23.5%

SATURDAY AGAINST FRIDAY ON 3,321 SCREENS. THE WEEKEND SHAPE OF A FILM WITH NO SECOND AUDIENCE, WHATEVER THE PEOPLE WHO SAW IT THOUGHT OF IT¹

THE SCEPTIC · STATE THE TWO NUMBERS, SKIP THE OBITUARY

A **\$125m** negative has taken **\$23.0m** worldwide through Tuesday, with international figures studio-reported rather than audited. On the standard theatrical split that is a long way from whole, before marketing. This desk has no sourced write-down figure and prints none. Named dissent, for the record: one critic called it “**insufferably smug and self-important**”; another wrote that it “**overstates everything, including its own importance**”. *Sight & Sound* praised Cruise's “**barnstorming performance**” in the same week.¹²

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's domestic release page for *Digger* and The Numbers' title page, both read at source, for the screen count, the opening weekend, every daily figure and its percentage change, the running domestic total through Tuesday 6 October, the worldwide figure and the US\$125,000,000 production budget. The daily rows carry an explicit flag marking them final rather than estimated, which is the basis for calling the weekend an actual. International components are studio-reported. A budget of US\$180m circulating elsewhere could not be sourced and is not printed. The Numbers separately lists a US\$1.2m preview figure that it does not include in its running total; it is excluded here too. 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic pages for the film, read at source, for both critic and audience figures with their sample sizes, the published critics' consensus and the quoted reviews. 3 Box Office Mojo's release page for *Verity* and The Numbers' daily domestic chart for 6 October, both read at source; the comparison of the weekend-chart header with the per-release daily flags is this desk's own reading of the two pages. 4 The Official Charts Company's albums chart for the week of 2–8 October 2026 and its licensed mirror of the American albums chart for 7–13 October, both read at source, for every position, climb and week count. Billboard's own pages returned a payment gateway, so the units, the streaming split and the percentage rise are carried from a syndicating outlet citing Billboard and Luminat, and are flagged as such. No units figure is published for the British chart. The critical reception of the expanded edition is summarised from an aggregator's compilation that this desk could not open directly, and is characterised rather than scored. 5 Box Office Mojo's release calendar for 9 October 2026, read at source.

The week's actual winner is the film *nobody* argued about. *Verity* opened the same day on 3,510 screens, took **US\$32,031,011** — also an actual — and reached **\$37.99m** domestically by Tuesday, **\$64.3m** worldwide.³

THE CHATTER · A CHART MOVE BOUGHT WITH FOUR TRACKS

Taylor Swift's *The Life of a Showgirl* went **21 to 1** in the United States and **84 to 1** in Britain in the same week — a thirteenth non-consecutive week on top, on **173,000** equivalent units, up **619%**. The cause was a four-track digital expansion released on 25 September with no physical edition on sale in the tracking week, so **136,000** of those units are streaming. The expansion's own critical reception was poor. No fan-community read is offered here: Reddit refused this desk entirely.⁴

IN BRIEF

Setting the record straight. No. 124 printed weekend estimates as actuals; No. 125 corrected them. The underlying confusion is now resolved: the weekend chart page still carries an “estimates” header while printing to-the-dollar figures, but the per-release daily tables flag every row as final. No. 125's **\$32,031,011** for *Verity* was correctly printed as an actual.³

Friday is the quarter's heaviest date — four studio wides on 9 October, with twenty-five titles dated that day in all. No screen counts or tracking figures are published yet, so this is a diary line and not a forecast.⁵

Catalogue is eating the British top ten: Oasis at six in its **682nd** week and at nine in its **769th**; Michael Jackson at five in his 278th; Fleetwood Mac at ten in a 411th. Two strong new entries sat behind Swift at two and three.⁴

ACTUALS, NOT ESTIMATES

13TH WEEK

THE FAMILY DESK · HER PHONE, AT TWELVE

Seven in ten already had one at twelve

A cohort of nearly nine thousand children says owning a phone at twelve tracks eating-disorder symptoms two years later. The ratios are large; the absolute numbers are small. Both are true.

The exposure in this study is not screen time. It is the single binary decision a parent of a twelve-year-old actually makes. Published in *JAMA Network Open* on 1 September, it follows **8,957** American children in the Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development cohort, of whom **6,225 — 69.5% — owned a smartphone at twelve.**¹

Two years on, adjusted for sex, income, parental education, pubertal status, depressive and attention symptoms, parental monitoring, other devices and body weight, the owners reported more of every symptom measured: binge eating at a risk ratio of **1.67**, compensatory behaviours at **1.50**, self-worth tied to weight at **2.03**, and any symptom at **1.49.**¹

Now the half the ratios hide. At fourteen, self-worth tied to weight was reported by **7.8%** of owners against **3.5%** of non-owners — a real doubling, of a small number. The measure worth carrying is the broadest: **any symptom, 24.2% against 15.5%.** Not a rounding error, and not an epidemic.¹

47% and 71%

SINGAPORE CHILDREN AGED **10–12** EXCEEDING THE RECOMMENDED TWO HOURS OF NON-SCHOOLWORK SCREEN TIME ON WEEKDAYS AND WEEKENDS, IN THE COMMUNICATIONS MINISTRY'S FIRST DIGITAL-PARENTING SURVEY OF 1,986 PARENTS. IN THE 7–9 BAND IT IS 27% ON WEEKDAYS²

DON'T BE ALARMIST · WHAT THE AUTHORS THEMSELVES SAY

The paper is unusually plain about its limits. Ownership “**was not randomized and reverse causation cannot be ruled out, so causality cannot be established**”, and “**residual confounding may remain**”. It captures no content and no usage pattern — only whether a phone exists. It does not adjust for bullying or for neurodevelopmental conditions. And a child who is already preoccupied with her body is a child who may be given, or may ask for, a phone. The direction of that arrow is exactly what this design cannot see.¹

What it supplies is a timing question, not a verdict. Its own framing is that *when* ownership starts may matter, not that phones cause illness — and the useful move is not confiscation but knowing which symptoms to watch for.¹

THE CHATTER · CONFIDENCE IS THE MISSING VARIABLE

The Singapore survey's sharpest figure is not about children. **Only 37% of parents felt confident guiding their child's digital habits.** The barriers they named were time, a child's reluctance to follow rules, children routing around parental controls, and not knowing what the controls do. Concerns ran to inappropriate content at **81%**, strangers at 57% and cyberbullying at 54%.²

The five symptoms are worth naming, because they are what the instrument actually asked about and they are observable at a kitchen table: eating a large amount with a sense of loss of control; behaviour intended to undo a meal; worry about gaining weight; self-worth that rises and falls with the scale; and any of the above. At twelve, in this cohort, **16.1%** of phone owners reported at least one, against **11.3%** of non-owners — before any of them turned fourteen.¹

WORTH KNOWING

The band a Singapore twelve-year-old sits in is 7–12, not 13–18 — under two hours a day of non-schoolwork screen use, on the health ministry's guidance as quoted in government parenting material. She leaves that band in July 2027.³

RR 1.49

24.2% V 15.5%

NOT CAUSAL

SOURCES 1 Nagata JM, Wong JH, Talebloo J and colleagues, “Smartphone Ownership and Eating Disorder Symptoms in Early Adolescence”, *JAMA Network Open*, 1 September 2026, 9(9):e2637897; open access, abstract and full text both read at source. Prospective cohort within the Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development study, 21 US sites, cross-sectional and two-year longitudinal analyses of study years two to six, Poisson models with a log link. Exposure parent-reported; outcomes adolescent-reported through the KSADS at ages 12 and 14. All ratios are the paper's covariate-adjusted figures and all percentages its weighted prevalences. No conflicts of interest reported. This is an observational cohort, not a trial, and the quoted limitations are the authors' own words. 2 The Ministry of Digital Development and Information's inaugural Digital Parenting Survey, published 12 September 2025, fieldwork February 2025, 1,986 Singapore resident parents of children aged 2 to 17, margin of error 2.2% at 95% confidence; read at source. 3 The under-two-hours guidance for ages 7 to 12 is the health ministry's, quoted here as it appears in government parenting material: the ministry's own page returned 404 on every path this desk tried, so the wording is carried at one remove and flagged as such. **General guidance for parents, not medical advice.** A parent with a specific concern about a specific child should speak to a doctor.

THE TWEEN YEARS · A YEAR OF EXTRA SPORT

Forty weeks of hard PE bought fifty-five metres

A randomised trial across thirty Danish schools improved exactly what it trained. Wellbeing, motivation and self-concept did not move at all.

This is the design the screen-time literature cannot manage: an actual randomised trial, in the right age band, at scale. Thirty Danish schools, **82 classes, 1,652 pupils** aged ten to thirteen, half of them girls. Classes were allocated to three extra forty-minute high-intensity sessions a week, or to ordinary PE, for about **forty weeks**.¹

The primary outcome was cardiorespiratory fitness on a shuttle-run test. The intervention won it: **+54.9 metres**, with a confidence interval running from **8.35 to 101.40**. Agility improved. Lower-body power improved. That is the whole list.¹

Everything else was null. No effect on health-related quality of life, on physical self-concept, on motivation for physical activity, or on the satisfaction of basic psychological needs — nor on balance, grip strength, body composition, blood pressure or resting heart rate. The authors are direct about it: further modifications “**may be needed to strengthen the effects on psychological outcomes**”. A two-year follow-up will be reported separately.¹

8.35 metres

THE LOWER BOUND OF THE CONFIDENCE INTERVAL ON A YEAR'S WORTH OF THREE EXTRA HIGH-INTENSITY PE LESSONS A WEEK. THE POINT ESTIMATE IS 54.9M; THE HONEST READING IS “SOMEWHERE BETWEEN NEGLIGIBLE AND A HUNDRED METRES”¹

THE SCEPTIC · FITNESS PROGRAMMES PRODUCE FITNESS

The useful lesson is not that school sport is pointless — it is that the thing you train is the thing that improves, and the warm claims attached to youth-sport programmes rarely survive measurement. If a school sells a PE initiative on confidence, belonging or motivation, this is the trial to ask it about: 1,652 children, forty weeks, randomised by class, and not one of those outcomes moved.¹

THE CHATTER · THE BELIEF THAT BREAKS, AND WHEN

A four-wave Chinese panel followed **524** children from ages ten to thirteen through to eighteen to twenty-one. Belief in meritocracy fell in everyone — more steeply among those who reached university. Only that group grew more *non-meritocratic*, and those shifts tracked steeper rises in depression. The authors add, properly, that **causality cannot be inferred**. The reason it belongs on this page is the timing: the conviction that effort decides outcomes is near its peak at twelve.²

There is a second reading, less comfortable. The trial ran three extra sessions a week for an academic year — a dose no Singapore secondary timetable is going to find — and the gain it produced sits inside the range a child of this age would cover by growing. The authors report significant effects of time across several measures, which is the polite way of saying the control classes also got fitter, because they were eleven and then they were twelve.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

The phone question has a Singapore answer with a number on it — 47% of ten-to-twelves over the recommended two hours on weekdays, 71% at weekends (p12). The jump from the 7–9 band is the striking part: 27% to 47% in three years.³

And a measurement note covering both studies. One reports prevalence ratios on an observational cohort of nearly nine thousand; the other reports metres on a randomised trial of sixteen hundred. The bigger number is the weaker evidence. Only the trial can say what a decision will do; the cohort can only say what to watch for — and a parent reading either in a headline will be given the ratio, never the interval.¹

RANDOMISED

NULL ON WELLBEING

SOURCES 1 Ciment C, Thøgersen-Ntoumani C, Larsen MN and colleagues, “One-Year Effects of the FIT FIRST 20 High-Intensity and Multisport Physical Education Program on Physical Fitness and Psychological Outcomes in Early Adolescents: A Cluster-Randomized Controlled Trial”, *Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports*, October 2026, 36(10):e70374; trial registration ISRCTN14624515; read at source. Cluster-randomised by class across 30 Danish schools; linear mixed-effects models adjusted for sex, baseline sport participation, age, body mass and height, the last two dropped from the psychological models. The quoted conclusion is the authors'. No conflicts declared. 2 Fan S, John OP, De Fruyt F, “Disillusionment With Meritocracy During the Transition to Adulthood”, *Psychological Science*, online ahead of print 23 September 2026; abstract read at source. Four-wave panel drawn from the China Family Panel Studies, n=524, 2012 to 2020. The sample is small and Chinese, and the depression finding sits at ages 18 to 21, not 12; it is carried here for its timing, not as a finding about a Singapore twelve-year-old. 3 The Ministry of Digital Development and Information's Digital Parenting Survey, as at note 2 on p12. **General guidance for parents, not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK • THE WINDOW YOU CHOOSE

Pick the start date and the answer changes

Almost the whole rise in the ten-year is real yield. Whether that is ninety-one per cent or a hundred depends entirely on where you begin counting.

The Federal Reserve raised rates on 16 September, twelve votes to nil, to **3¾–4%**. The minutes landed on Wednesday and said another increase “**would likely be appropriate**” by year end. The ten-year touched **5.365%** intraday, its highest since 2002, and closed at **5.28%**.¹

Strip the inflation component out and almost nothing is left. Against the Treasury’s own two daily curves, the ten-year is up **49bp since 1 September**, of which **48bp is real** — 98%. Over the shorter window this desk used in No. 124, the rise is 32bp and the real share is **90.6%**. Since 1 October it is 4bp and **100%**. Three honest windows, three different shares, and the only reason No. 125’s figure read 106% is that it began where breakevens had fallen.²

2.36%

THE TEN-YEAR BREAKEVEN AT THE CLOSE ON **1, 2, 5, 6 AND 7 OCTOBER** — UNMOVED TO TWO DECIMALS FOR FIVE CONSECUTIVE SESSIONS. THE MARKET IS NOT REPRICING INFLATION. IT IS REPRICING THE COST OF MONEY.²

THE LEVELS • WEDNESDAY 7 OCTOBER

US 2-year	4.77%	▼ 7bp
US 10-year	5.28%	▲ 1bp
10-year real	2.92%	▲ 1bp
VWRA	\$193.34	▼ 1.15%
AGGU	\$5.72	▼ 0.19%
DXY	102.27	▲ 0.43%
Brent	\$100.95	▲ 0.37%
Gold	\$4,136.70	▼ 1.20%
Bitcoin	\$83,338	▼ 2.66%

Treasury series at Wednesday’s close; the two funds are London closes, before New York. Not advice.³

The term premium is doing the work the rate path is not. The New York Fed’s own file puts the ten-year premium at **0.9621 on 5 October** — the highest since **2 July 2014**. Of the 77bp rise in the fitted ten-year

SOURCES 1 The Federal Reserve’s own minutes of the 15–16 September 2026 meeting, released 7 October and read at source, for the decision, the unanimous vote and the quoted year-end language. The intraday high is a live blog, not the Treasury series; cnbc.com returned HTTP 403 to this desk and its report was not read directly. 2 Computed by this desk from the US Treasury’s daily par yield curve and daily real yield curve, both downloaded and read. Both are par-curve series, so the implied breakeven is a proxy rather than a true zero-coupon figure: direction and magnitude are sound, the level approximate. No. 124’s 91% and No. 125’s 106% are reconciled here rather than corrected — each was arithmetically right on its own window. 3 Treasury as above; VWRA, AGGU, the dollar index, Brent, gold and bitcoin from exchange and fund quote pages read at source at Wednesday’s close, with the London closes struck at 16:35–17:09 GMT, ahead of New York. The Straits Times Index closed at **5,608.44**, down 1.63%. 4 The New York Fed’s ACM term-premium workbook, downloaded and parsed locally. The 2 July 2014 comparison is this desk’s own scan of the full daily series. The file’s last observation is 6 October, so Wednesday’s move is not yet in it. 5 The JPMorgan line as carried in a market live blog of 7 October. The auction detail — including a reported clearing yield and the dealers’ reaction — reached this desk only as search summaries behind a 403 and is described, deliberately, without a number. 6 Prices as at note 3; Neumann’s remarks from a Reuters instant-view panel of 1 October, read at source. No verified official-sector gold purchase figure for the third quarter was obtainable, so no central-bank cushion is asserted here. This desk explains market moves; it does not give investment advice, and forecasts are flagged as forecasts.

since 30 June, **57% is term premium** rather than expected policy. This also settles a figure in circulation: the premium for 1 October was **0.9047**, not the 1.45 that had been going round.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • THE BIGGEST BANK SAYS THE OPPOSITE

JPMorgan analysts wrote that they “**do not see evidence that levels have overrun moves in Fed expectations**” — a justified repricing, not a premium blowout. The Fed’s own data says otherwise. Both cannot hold. And the demand-strike story failed its test the same afternoon: the ten-year backed off its high **after the auction went well**. If buyers appear at those yields, nobody-wants-Treasuries is not the story.⁵

What broke on Wednesday was the hedge. Global equities fell 1.15%, global bonds 0.19%, gold 1.20% and bitcoin 2.66% — and the dollar rose. Across the week the bond leg returned precisely nothing: AGGU closed at 5.72 having started at 5.72. When the real discount rate is the single moving part, it is the numerator problem for both legs at once, and the only thing that diversified was cash.³

THE CHATTER • WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

Gold has stopped ignoring real yields: it peaked at **\$4,202** on 1 October with the real yield at its window low, and bottomed Wednesday at its window high. Bitcoin fell **2.2× as far as gold** on identical drivers and sits **32.9% below** its 52-week high while gold sits near its own. In a twelve-year-high term-premium regime, the asset with no cash flow and no official bid has lost a third; the one with an official bid has not. HSBC’s Fred Neumann names the cause as “**large government deficits and enormous funding demand from the AI sector**” — see **p7**.⁶

HIGHER FOR LONGER, ROUND TWO

TERM PREMIUM 12-YR HIGH

DOLLAR BID

THE RABBIT HOLE • LISTENING TO SPACECRAFT

A picture of the Earth falls onto your screen

No licence, no transmitter, no exam. A stick of silicon, a wire on a pole, and ten minutes of a satellite crossing your sky — and the network you join has four and a half thousand stations, of which under three hundred are awake.

You transmit nothing. That is the premise. Weather satellites in low orbit broadcast their pictures continuously and unencrypted as they pass; several hundred university and hobby cubesats beacon their battery voltages and temperatures on amateur frequencies. All of it already arrives at your roof. The hobby is catching it.¹

The physics reduces to one problem: a satellite in low orbit crosses your sky in eight to fifteen minutes, its frequency sliding as it comes and goes. Every piece of gear in this world solves that one sentence — how to hear a faint, moving, frequency-shifting transmitter for ten minutes, twice a day.¹

THE CHATTER • THE MOMENT PEOPLE DESCRIBE

It is always the same moment, and always the first one. In September a poster put up a first image from a Korean geostationary weather satellite caught on a **cardboard dish lined with tinfoil**: “the wind would blow all of the foil around and I would end up losing sync however it still kinda worked!” Another, days later, on a copper V-dipole taped to PVC pipe: **“I’m pretty new to this, so I am incredibly proud of these results.”** A third, in Mumbai, logged his first waterfall on a stock whip and a Raspberry Pi.²

The organised half is **SatNOGS** — the Satellite Networked Open Ground Station network, run by the Greek non-profit Libre Space Foundation. You build a station, register it, and it takes scheduling orders from a web service: strangers book your antenna, it records the pass unattended, and the recording lands in a public archive. A hobby and a piece of scientific infrastructure at once — which is the tension the whole scene runs on.³

4,510 → 298

GROUND STATIONS EVER REGISTERED, AGAINST THOSE ONLINE WHEN THIS DESK QUERIED THE NETWORK ON 7 OCTOBER. **1,390 HAVE NEVER ONCE BEEN SEEN ONLINE** — WHILE THE FOUNDATION’S OWN HOMEPAGE ADVERTISES “500+” STATIONS AND 322 LIVE³

That gap is not a scandal; it is the shape of a volunteer sensor network. Roofs change hands, students graduate, a Pi dies in a Greek summer. But know it before picturing a humming global array: **536 stations** were seen in the past week. The archive is enormous regardless — **over fifteen million observations** and **313.9 million telemetry frames** across 1,728 satellites.³

THE SCEPTIC • THE SIGNAL THAT MADE THE HOBBY IS GONE

The analogue transmission that created this pastime in the 1970s no longer exists. The American weather agency decommissioned **NOAA-18 on 6 June 2025**, **NOAA-19 on 13 August** and **NOAA-15 on 19 August**. Observers logged the last picture as it stopped. The pinned beginners’ index now reads, flatly: **“These satellites have been decommissioned, receive Meteor instead.”**⁴

They arrive from four directions — astronomers who own a mount and understand orbits, radio amateurs who own the antennas, self-hosting types happy to leave a Pi running, and space enthusiasts. Nobody sits an exam, because nobody transmits. The satisfaction is forensic rather than social: you are not making a contact, you are recovering a signal.¹

What follows: where this community gathers and what it argues about; the gear, at the tiers worth buying and the one that is a trap; what it genuinely costs; and an honest ninety days for someone starting on Thursday.

NO LICENCE

298 ONLINE

APT IS DEAD

SOURCES 1 The Libre Space Foundation’s own SatNOGS documentation and wiki, read at source 7 October 2026. 2 Three posts on the r/amateursatellites forum, 23 and 29 September 2026 and 5 April 2026, and a SatNOGS community-forum post of 28 August 2026, all read at source and quoted as written; usernames are withheld here but the posts are public. 3 Figures computed by this desk from the SatNOGS network and database public interfaces, queried 7 October 2026: station states and last-seen dates from the stations endpoint, observation count from the latest issued identifier, telemetry-frame and satellite counts from the published statistics tables. The Foundation’s homepage counters were read the same day and differ from the live interface, which is noted rather than resolved. 4 The American National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration’s own polar-satellite status page for all three decommissioning dates and times; observer reports of the final transmissions from the SatNOGS community forum, read at source; the quoted line is the current pinned index on r/amateursatellites.

THE DEEP END · THE GEAR AND THE ARGUMENT

The best station on the network has no rotator

Four hundred and thirty-nine thousand observations, three fixed antennas and a switch. The expensive radios buy bandwidth, not pictures.

Where they gather: **r/RTLSDR** at 139,200 members is the big room; **r/amateursatellites** at 38,300 is the one that matters here; the Libre Space community forum carries the project itself, its largest boards running to 759 and 585 threads. The dedicated weather-satellite subreddit has **four members**.¹

The receiver is the cheap part and it has been for a decade. An **RTL-SDR Blog V4** dongle is about **US\$40**; the house's newer lite model with the replacement tuner lists at **US\$37.95**. Above it sit Airspy and SDRplay for a better front end. Above them, the serious radios: a **LimeSDR Mini 2.0** at **US\$600**, a **bladeRF 2.0 micro xA4** at **US\$540**, an **Ettus B200mini** at **US\$1,503**.²

Here is the sentence the community repeats and the one a buy-once reader should hear first: for the 137MHz pictures that everyone starts with, **nothing above the cheapest decent dongle buys you a better image**. The expensive radios buy **bandwidth** — the 1.7GHz high-resolution downlinks need several megahertz, X-band far more — not sensitivity. The one station on the whole network running an Ettus has been offline since 2022.²

\$149 + \$125

A 70CM THREE-PETAL DISCOVERY DISH AND AN L-BAND FEED — THE PURCHASE THAT REORGANISED THIS HOBBY. AN 1.7GHZ STATION FOR UNDER THREE HUNDRED DOLLARS, WHERE IT USED TO MEAN A SCRAPYARD DISH AND A WEEKEND OF BRACKETS²

THE SCEPTIC · THE ROTATOR IS THE MONEY PIT

It is the dividing line everyone imagines and the one the data does not support. The top station on the network, with **439,336 observations**, runs no rotator at all: a stainless quadrifilar helix, an eggbeater, an L-band omni and a switch. The third-highest, also rotatorless, has 397,841. Across the network, **2,534 declared antennas are omnidirectional** against 1,579 of the directional kind. A fixed antenna sees the whole sky and has nothing to break.³

If you want one, the ladder is short. The project's open-hardware rotator costs **US\$300–400** in parts by its own estimate; a builder who finished one itemised **\$370–450**. A portable unit sells at **US\$325**, reviewed as working but **“not suitable for permanent satellite receiver setups”**. The standard is a **Yaesu** at **US\$969.99**; from **23 October** a weatherproof alternative at **US\$799**, funded by 309 backers, which nobody has taken through a winter.⁴

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE OPEN HARDWARE IS ACTUALLY WORTH

Count the station descriptions and the romance evaporates. Across 4,510 of them, **“Yaesu” appears 84 times** and **“SatNOGS rotator” ten**. The open design is a niche flex, not the endgame — and the forum says why. One builder, in February: the guide's 404 means **“I can't even start sourcing parts.”** Two months later he had still not begun and called the forum “a joke”; another called the documentation “an absolute mess”. A third asked which of two conflicting arm lengths was correct and got no answer.⁵

Nobody sells an assembled station — no kit vendor, no waitlist, no commissioning service. What exists is a handful of small antenna makers bought from by name, in Slovakia, Germany, Australia and the United States, plus the forum's build threads.⁵

84 AGAINST 10

SOURCES 1 Subreddit member counts and the community forum's board index, read at source 7 October 2026. 2 Vendor store pages read at source 7 October 2026 for every price quoted, in the sellers' own currency; the dish and feed prices and the campaign figures from the maker's crowdfunding page. The verdict that sensitivity is not the constraint at 137MHz is the community's, recurring across the forum and the subreddit; the detail about the single Ettus-equipped station is this desk's own reading of the station register. 3 Observation counts and antenna-type tallies computed by this desk from the SatNOGS network interface, queried 7 October 2026; station descriptions are their operators' own text. 4 The project's own wiki for the open rotator's parts estimate and specification; a builder's itemised figure from a forum post of 27 February 2025; the portable unit's price from its marketplace listing and the quoted verdict from a published review; the Yaesu price from a United States dealer, read at source; the new rotator's price, ship date, backer count and funding total from its campaign page, with its most recent update of 2 September 2026 reporting compliance testing still in progress. 5 Counts of the strings in station descriptions are this desk's own. The quoted complaints are forum posts of February and April 2025 and March 2026, read at source. The named antenna makers are those recurring in station descriptions and forum recommendations; one long-standing British supplier's domain now redirects elsewhere and whether it still trades could not be established.

THE DEEP END · THE COSTS AND THE CATALOGUE

The orbital catalogue ran out of numbers in July

A punched-card format from the 1960s has five digits for a satellite identifier. In July the register passed a hundred thousand objects, and none of this network's software can read the ones above it.

Every tracker in this hobby is fed by a two-line element set — a fixed-column layout inherited from punched cards, with five characters for the catalogue number. On **11 July 2026** the official register ran past 99,999; it now stands above **100,954**. The format physically cannot carry a six-digit identifier, and the custodians are pushing everyone to a modern replacement.¹

The network has not got there. A maintainer, on 22 September: “**Currently none of the SatNOGS components support orbital data with NORAD ID >99999.**” A contributor published a conformance corpus of eighteen real cases the same week and found that a naive five-digit parser fails thirteen of sixteen. The fix had not shipped by 5 October, having slipped behind a launch.¹

THE CHATTER · EVERYONE RUNS THE UNRELEASED VERSION

The universal decoder in this hobby reports itself as **2.0.0-alpha**. Its last tagged stable release is **1.2.2, dated 28 November 2024** — nearly two years old. Forum posts have been casually citing “2.0.0” since last November as though it shipped. The companion receiver software tells users outright that its nightlies are “**usually just stable as normal releases**” and arrive minutes after a change is pushed. Running unreleased software is not a quirk here; it is the culture.²

What it costs, honestly, at three levels. **Dabbling:** a dongle at **US\$38–40**, a filtered preamplifier, and a wire dipole you make — under a hundred dollars, and it will produce a weather picture. **Committed:** the **US\$149** dish with a **US\$125** L-band feed, a better receiver, a Pi and an outdoor enclosure at **US\$185** — call it six to eight hundred, and you are decoding high-resolution imagery. **Serious:** add a rotator and directional antennas and you are past two thousand before the mast.³

SOURCES 1 The orbital-data custodian's own published notice of the five-digit exhaustion, dated 11 July 2026, and its statement that the legacy format will not support higher catalogue numbers, read at source; an amateur-satellite bulletin of 19 July 2026 carrying the same; the maintainer's quoted comment and the conformance corpus from the SatNOGS community forum, 22 September 2026, read at source, with the corpus deposited under a published digital-object identifier. 2 Version strings and release histories read at source on the projects' own repositories and documentation sites, 7 October 2026; the quoted line about nightlies is the receiver project's own README. 3 Prices as at note 2 on **p16**, all read at source in the sellers' currencies; the ninety-day ordering is this desk's synthesis of the community's own recommended path, and the quoted warning is from a widely-cited guide to the band. The count of declared quadrifilar-helix antennas is this desk's own tally of station records. 4 Registration years computed by this desk from the creation dates of all 4,510 station records, queried 7 October 2026; the never-online figure from the same dump's last-seen field.

619 and 539

NEW STATIONS REGISTERED IN 2025, AND IN 2026 TO 7 OCTOBER — THE STRONGEST TWO YEARS SINCE 2019'S 687. THE NETWORK IS GROWING AGAIN EVEN AS THE SIGNAL THAT FOUNDED THE HOBBY GOES QUIET⁴

The first ninety days, in the order that wastes least money. Spend week one reading the subreddit's pinned index and watching a pass predicted on free software, buying nothing. Then the dongle, a filtered preamplifier for the 137MHz band, and a self-built quadrifilar helix from published plans — **634 stations on the network declare one**. Decode the Russian low-rate pair, which is now the entire entry level. Only when that is routine should the dish arrive. Do not start at X-band: the best-known guide to it opens by saying it is not a tutorial and telling you not to begin there.³

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE COMMUNITY ADMITS WHEN PRESSED

Three things. The hobby's founding signal is dead and the replacements are a single Russian pair. The open hardware is under-documented to the point where builders give up in public. And a registered station is a commitment, not a trophy: **1,390 of them never came online at all**, and the median station on this network is a Raspberry Pi somebody stopped maintaining. The archive is magnificent; the attrition is the price of it.⁴

NEXT DESCENTS

Leathercraft — veg-tan against chrome, the saddle stitch, and a tool roll that outlives you.

Competitive pistol & air-rifle target shooting — the most regulated hobby a Singaporean can licence.

Tropical fish & freshwater aquascaping — the Amano school, and a tank that is really a garden.

100,954 OBJECTS

1,390 NEVER ONLINE

FITNESS · THE LEVER THAT DOES NOTHING

Your strength swings eleven per cent. Train anyway

A Basel trial timed older adults' training to their own measured best and worst hours for twelve weeks. Three confidence intervals, all straddling zero.

This is the page for anyone who schedules around a readiness score. Researchers at Basel took **108** adults aged sixty to eighty, tested each one's strength at **08:00, 12:00, 16:00 and 20:00** on four days, and used the results to find every individual's peak and trough. Then they randomised people to train at their best hour, their worst, or not at all, for twelve weeks. **93** were analysed.¹

The diurnal effect measured at baseline is real and large: isometric mid-thigh pull came in at **25.9 newtons per kilo at peak against 23.3 at trough** — a mean swing of about **11%**, individuals ranging from **1% to 34%**. You genuinely are stronger at one end of your day.¹

It made no difference to anything. Peak against trough, adjusted: mid-thigh pull **+0.06, with a confidence interval from -0.76 to 0.88**; grip strength **-0.21 (-0.68 to 0.26)**; appendicular lean mass **+0.03 (-0.09 to 0.15)**. Three intervals, all through zero. The authors conclude that individualised timing is unlikely to deliver a clinically meaningful benefit.¹

91–94%

ADHERENCE IN BOTH TRAINING ARMS, SUPERVISED AT ONE PHYSIOLOGIST PER THREE TO FIVE PARTICIPANTS. ADHERENCE IS THE VARIABLE THAT MOVED; TIMING IS THE ONE THAT DID NOT.¹

The protocol is specific enough to copy, and the null result is the permission slip. Twelve weeks, three sessions a week — two resistance, one endurance. A fortnight of familiarisation at **three sets of twenty, light**. Then from week three: **three sets of eight to fifteen reps to failure**, the same load across all three, on five movements — single-leg press, chest press, deadlift, one-arm cable row, back squat. The progression rule is one line: clear fifteen and add load; drop below eight and take it off. The third

session is **thirty minutes of cycling at 60% of VO₂peak**.¹

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A NULL CAN AND CANNOT SAY

It was powered to detect a moderate effect — **d = 0.51** — so it excludes a worthwhile benefit, not a small one. Peak and trough came from a single four-day profile, which the authors call “**an estimate rather than a definitive determination**”. The cohort averaged **67**. The defensible sentence is not that timing does not matter, but that the best-controlled test of it found nothing, in people with more to gain than a mid-forties reader has.¹

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE ARGUMENT ACTUALLY LIVES

A second null is harder to dismiss: a British trial randomised 36 adults to morning or evening resistance work for six weeks, found main effects of training on insulin sensitivity, muscle thickness and torque — and **no time-of-day interaction on any**. Its conclusion is to train **at convenient times**. But a Lahore trial of **150** sedentary adults found chronotype-aligned aerobic work cut systolic pressure **10.8mmHg against 5.5**. Different mode, different outcome — and no confidence intervals published at all.²

ALSO WORTH THE MINUTE

Test at the same hour, always. The one genuinely useful thing the circadian data gives a self-quantifier: with an 11% daily swing, a nine-o'clock retest will “prove” a programme a seven-o'clock retest would have disproved. That is a measurement rule, not a training one.¹

Frequency, with the caveat attached. A twelve-month trial in 118 completers aged sixty-plus cut epicardial fat **15.15ml** against control; each extra weekly session was associated with a further 3.156ml — on an **R² of 0.084**. Under nine per cent of the variance, and the paper's own word is “associated”.³

NULL RESULT

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

SOURCES 1 Bruggisser F, Ritter S, Roth R and colleagues, “Effects of Daily Rhythm-Aligned Training on Skeletal Muscle Adaptation in Older Adults: A Randomized Controlled Trial”, *Journal of Cachexia, Sarcopenia and Muscle*, 25 September 2026, 17(5):e70390; open access, full text read at source. Double-blind three-arm parallel-group trial, permuted-block randomisation, University of Basel, November 2023 to June 2025; registered on ClinicalTrials.gov. 115 assessed, 108 randomised, 93 analysed; mean age 67; 41% female. All effect estimates and intervals are the paper's own adjusted figures, and every limitation quoted is from the authors' own methodological-considerations section. Publicly funded by the Swiss National Science Foundation with one declared conflict unrelated to the work. 2 Dighriri A, Lithgow H, Gabriel B and colleagues, *Experimental Physiology*, March 2026, 111(3):1109–1119, abstract read at source, for the six-week trial, its three non-significant interaction terms and its stated conclusion; the authors note no formal power analysis was conducted, which is why it is carried here as support rather than proof. Tariq A, Harris Khalid M, Ammar M, *Open Heart*, 14 April 2026, 13(1):e003573, abstract read at source, for the Lahore trial; it reports no confidence intervals and publishes no numbers for its other claimed outcomes, which is stated above rather than glossed. 3 Xue X, Chen S, Cheng Y and colleagues, *Frontiers in Public Health*, 16 September 2026, 14:1938784, abstract read at source. **General guidance, not medical advice.** Anyone with a cardiovascular, metabolic or musculoskeletal condition should clear a new programme with a clinician first.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

The race is this weekend and the walkabouts are going

Every row below was put back to a promoter, a venue or an official box office this morning. Two of the biggest names in the window publish no price at all.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 9–11 OCT** ★ **Formula 1 Singapore Grand Prix**
MARINA BAY STREET CIRCUIT, THIS WEEKEND. EVERY HOSPITALITY TIER **SOLD OUT**; ZONE 4 WALKABOUT **S\$198 FRI / S\$298 SAT / S\$368 SUN**, TURN 1 THREE-DAY **S\$1,698**. THE OFFICIAL STORE WARNS UNOFFICIAL TICKETS “**WILL BE VOIDED WITHOUT REFUND**”¹
- 3–5 NOV** **Trevor Noah — stand-up**
THE STAR THEATRE, THREE NIGHTS. **S\$128–268**, EIGHT PER TRANSACTION. ADULT MATERIAL²
- 25 NOV** **Guns N’ Roses — World Tour**
NATIONAL STADIUM, ONE NIGHT, DOORS 6PM. **BASE PRICES ARE NOT PUBLISHED** ON THE VENUE’S OWN PAGE — ONLY THE BOOKING FEES, \$6 TO \$10 BY BAND²
- 27–29 NOV** ★ **Anime Festival Asia Singapore**
SUNTEC, HALLS 401–406. **ONE DAY FROM S\$98**, THREE-DAY CAT 1 **S\$498**; WALK-UP RISES TO \$105. THE BEST FAMILY PICK IN THE WINDOW²
- 20–29 NOV** **Kalaa Utsavam — Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE. PRICED PER SHOW, **FROM S\$29**; THE CHILDREN’S COOKERY PIECE IS **S\$40**²
- 28–29 NOV** **SJ60 結 MUSUBI — Singapore-Japan Festival**
SANDS EXPO, BOTH DAYS 10AM–8PM. **ADMISSION PRICE NOT PUBLISHED**; THE ORGANISER SAYS DETAILS ARE STILL TO COME²
- 3–6 DEC** **Voices — A Festival of Song**
ESPLANADE. WORKSHOPS **FROM S\$15**, CONCERTS **FROM S\$28**²
- 21–31 JAN** **Singapore Art Week 2027**
CITYWIDE, OVERWHELMINGLY FREE. ART SG RUNS **22–24 JANUARY** AT SANDS EXPO WITH A VIP PREVIEW ON THE 21ST; NEITHER HAS PUBLISHED A 2027 PROGRAMME OR A TICKET PRICE³

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- 10–24 JAN** ★ **Hatsu Basho — Grand Sumo, January**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO, FIFTEEN DAYS. **CHAIR SEAT C FROM ¥3,500** WEEKDAY, **MASU BOX C ¥34,000–38,000** FOR FOUR. PRICES INCLUDE TAX, EXCLUDE HANDLING⁴
- 25–28 FEB** ★ **CP+ 2027 — Camera & Photo Imaging Show**
PACIFICO YOKOHAMA. **FREE, WITH WEB PRE-REGISTRATION**. OPENING DAY IS PRESS-ONLY UNTIL NOON; THE ONLINE HALF ARCHIVES THROUGH MARCH⁴
- 31 OCT–28 MAR** **Mariko Mori — All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI. **¥2,800 ONLINE WEEKDAY**, **¥3,000 AT THE DOOR AT WEEKENDS** — AND **FREE FOR JUNIOR-HIGH AND UNDER**⁴
- 14 NOV–28 MAR** **Masterworks from the Musée d’Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM, UENO, FOR THE BUILDING’S CENTENARY. **¥2,200 ADVANCE**; **FREE FOR EIGHTEEN AND UNDER**⁴
- 15–17 JAN** **Tokyo Auto Salon 2027**
MAKUHARI MESSE. **¥4,000** ON THE 15TH, **¥3,000** THEREAFTER, VALID FOR THE PRINTED DAY ONLY. **DIGITAL TICKETS ONLY**⁴
- 4–11 FEB** **Sapporo Snow Festival**
ODORI, TSUDOME AND SUSUKINO. **FREE TO ENTER**; THE TSUDOME SLIDES ARE INDIVIDUALLY PAID. THE STRONGEST TRAVEL-TIMING PLAY IN THE WINDOW⁴
- 11–31 JAN** **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE PARK. DATES AS PRINTED ON THE TOURNAMENT’S OWN MASTHEAD; TICKET PAGES NOT OPENED BY THIS DESK⁴

PLANNING NOTES

The race is the only thing here you cannot plan around: hospitality is gone and the walkabouts are moving, with a small batch held back for sale at the gates each day. For Tokyo in January, the sumo and the Auto Salon fall in the same fortnight and the museums run through both. And note what two of the biggest names in this list have in common — a stadium rock show and a national cultural festival, five and seven weeks out, **neither publishing a price**.²

SOURCES 1 The Grand Prix’s own ticket store and entertainment pages, read at source on 8 October 2026, for every price band, the sold-out hospitality tiers, the live availability labels and the quoted warning about unofficial tickets. 2 Each event’s official venue, promoter or festival page, read at source on 8 October 2026; where a price is absent above it is absent there. The Trevor Noah dates and bands come from the ticketing agency’s page source, which renders client-side and could not be read in full — that row is carried with the reservation that only the dates, venue and published bands were legible. 3 The festival’s and the fair’s own homepages, read at source 8 October 2026; both confirm dates, neither yet publishes a programme or a price. 4 Each institution’s or organiser’s own page, read at source 8 October 2026, in the local currency as published. No event listed here appears on this magazine’s barred-events ledger, and every row was re-verified against a primary page rather than a listings aggregator.

THE TABLE · TWO NEW, TWO JUDGED

A Tokyo yakitori counter, for fifteen seats and three months

Takuhei Yamada brings his fire to an Orchard balcony on 28 October. Elsewhere, two rooms that opened last year have finally been reviewed — and one of them is a theatre ticket with dinner attached.

The most interesting thing happening to this city's dinner table this quarter is a pop-up. **Torimitsu** is a thirteen-seat yakitori room in Ushigome-Kagurazaka whose chef-owner, Takuhei Yamada, trained in the Torishiki style before building his own method — thick skewers worked close to a hot binchotan fire, each moved nearer or further by hand. From **28 October to 28 January** he is cooking at **Tanuki Raw's** fourth-floor balcony on Orchard Road, dinner only, **fifteen seats**, everyone on the eight-skewer omakase.¹

No price has been published. The cancellation policy has: cancel inside four hours and you are charged **S\$20 a head**, because **"late cancellations have a big impact on our operations"**. It is al fresco and fan-cooled. **Too new to judge** — he has not served a skewer here, and the only coverage is a two-day-old announcement.¹

At the other end of the price list, **Wok & Toast** opened in Serangoon Central in early October — the first air-conditioned sit-down from The Neighbourwok, a Bukit Batok hawker operation whose Hokkien prawn mee earned a genuine queue. Nasi lemak **S\$7.80**, breakfast sets from **S\$5.80**. One published tasting note exists, and it is a reservation not a rave: the signature came out **"on the wetter side"** — precisely the thing Singapore argues about. Not halal-certified.²

THE BUZZ · THE VERDICT ON A S\$148 PERFORMANCE

Jeju Haenyeo, at The Arts House, has now been reviewed properly and three critics reached the same place by different routes. Time Out gave it **four out of five**, flagging that seafood is thin and kitchen light bleeds into the room. HungryGoWhere found the food homely but **"isn't mind-blowingly delicious"**. A third called the black pork **"the star of the show"** and the cooking **"well-seasoned and not necessarily mind-blowing"**. No forum thread exists that this desk could find.³

The number that settles it came from the reviewer who declared her meal hosted: the parent experience in Jeju runs under **S\$62**. Here it is **S\$148**. Worth doing once, knowing you are buying a theatre ticket with dinner attached. A weekend **12:30 matinee** has quietly appeared since launch — the least-booked slot, and it answers the complaint about stray light.³

And the one this desk would book: **Kappo Suguru**, a counter-only room in a Joo Chiat shophouse from the Suguru Home Dining team, serving kappo Sunday to Tuesday while a sushi concept takes the counter the rest of the week. Seasonal omakase **from S\$180++**. Not halal.⁴

THE HONESTY LEDGER · ONE REVIEW IS ONE REVIEW

Its verdict rests on a single scored review — taste four, **value four**, ambience **3.5**, overall four out of five — plus one supporting write-up. A real published judgement and a thin one: a single palate, not a consensus. The lowest of the four scores is the room, which for a **S\$250++** counter is the most useful signal in it. Nothing on the Michelin guide, nothing on the major food sites, no forum thread.⁴

S\$180++

TOO NEW TO CALL

S\$148 V S\$62

SOURCES 1 The pop-up's own reservation page and the host restaurant's listing, read at source 8 October 2026, for the dates, seat count, the mandatory omakase, the cancellation terms and the quoted line; the chef's lineage and the Tokyo restaurant's format from a Singapore food title's announcement of 6 October 2026, read at source. No review of the Singapore residency exists, because it has not opened; one major food site sat behind a challenge page and could not be read. 2 A Singapore food title's opening report of 7 October 2026 and its April 2026 piece on the parent hawker stall, both read at source, for the address, hours, every price and the quoted tasting note. No other outlet has covered it. 3 Time Out Singapore's scored review of 31 March 2026; HungryGoWhere's review of 31 December 2025, which declares a hosted tasting; and a third published review of 26 November 2025 — all read at source, all quoted as written. The Jeju comparison figure is HungryGoWhere's. Seating times, the new weekend matinee and the "reservation is a must" line were re-checked on the restaurant's own site on 8 October 2026. Searches for Singapore forum threads returned nothing, which is stated rather than filled. 4 A single scored review of 2 September 2026 and one supporting write-up, both read at source, for the scores, the menu and the quoted judgements; the venue's own channel, read 8 October 2026, for the two concepts, their separate booking pages and the days each takes the counter. Every venue on this page was checked against the Table ledger before selection; one candidate that opened recently was dropped because its previous run falls inside the seven-issue bar.

THE UNDERCURRENT · LAOS AND ORDER FORTY

A country stopped importing petrol cars to defend its currency

Laos is the first state in Asia to shut its border to combustion vehicles. It did it to stop paying for fuel in dollars — and the suspension expires in twelve weeks, with a prime minister three days into the job.

In late February, when the Strait of Hormuz closed, Thailand suspended its exports of refined fuel. Laos buys **97.54%** of its fuel from Thailand. It has no refinery. Within hours there was panic buying in Vientiane; within a week more than **40% of the country's 2,538 filling stations** were shut, and it took two hours to fill a motorcycle tank.¹

Then the prices. Diesel went from about **20,000 kip a litre at the end of February to 52,650 in early April** — a rise of over 160%, the worst fuel shock of any economy in Southeast Asia. Petrol rose 90%. At the April peak Lao diesel cost **US\$2.40 a litre** against Thailand's US\$1.60. Inflation went from 5.1% in January to **10.2%** in April while its neighbours ran between two and six.²

On **13 March** the prime minister signed **Order No. 40/PM**. It cut registration and service fees on electric vehicles by 30% and raised them on fuel vehicles by the same; it stopped the government buying petrol cars; it put ministries on rotating shifts and remote meetings; it ordered transport firms to run at least a tenth of their fleets electric by the end of this year; and it stood up a task force reporting to the prime minister daily. On **12 May** a further notice went much further: from 1 June to 31 December, **no fuel-powered vehicles may be imported at all**.³

3% against 25–90%

EXCISE DUTY ON AN ELECTRIC VEHICLE IN LAOS, AGAINST A CONVENTIONAL ONE — AND ANY BATTERY CAR UNDER US\$50,000 PAYS NO CONSUMPTION TAX EITHER. THE TAX WEDGE IS TENS OF PERCENTAGE POINTS OF LIST PRICE³

Read quickly, this is a climate story and a remarkable one: the first country in Asia, and the second in the world after Ethiopia, to stop petrol and diesel cars at the border. Read properly, it is nothing of the kind.

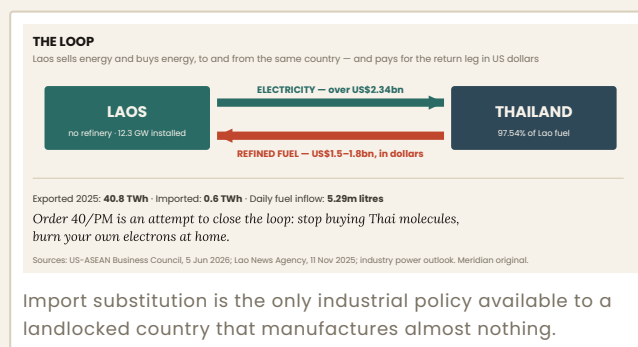
SOURCES 1 Fuel-supplier shares and the daily volume from the Lao News Agency's report of 11 November 2025 on the prime minister's own figures to the National Assembly, read at source; the station closures and the queues from an Agence France-Presse report of 16 March 2026, read at source via its syndicating outlet. 2 World Bank, *Lao PDR Economic Monitor*, June 2026 — the PDF was downloaded and its text extracted locally; pump prices, the regional comparison and the inflation path are read from its price section and its figure 11. 3 Order No. 40/PM of 13 March 2026, as reported by the Vientiane Times via Asia News Network and by a regional sustainability title, both read at source; this desk could not open the Lao official gazette and the order is attributed to those reports rather than to the gazette. The 12 May notice of the Prime Minister's Office carries no published number in any source read, including the Lao-language original. Excise and consumption-tax figures from two Lao English-language reports of June 2026, read at source. 4 The policy recommendation and its classification under energy security are the World Bank's own, from the report at note 2. Ethiopia's 2024 precedent is noted so that no claim of a world first is made here. 5 Electricity and petroleum trade values from a Washington trade-council analysis of 5 June 2026; the daily volume from a Lao English-language report of 3 June 2026; generation and export figures from a published industry outlook. All read at source. 6 World Bank, *Lao PDR Economic Monitor*, June 2026, box 1 and its figure 26, read from the downloaded PDF.

The World Bank files the recommendation to **“facilitate the transition to electric transport and equipment”** not under climate but under **energy security**. Laos is not electrifying to save the planet. It is electrifying to stop paying for molecules in US dollars.⁴

“Sometimes, we have money but there's no gas to buy.”

The trade this is meant to fix is circular, and Laos loses on both legs. It sells Thailand more than **US\$2.34bn** of electricity a year. It buys back from Thailand **US\$1.5–1.8bn** of refined petroleum — about **5.29 million litres a day**. It exported **40.8 terawatt-hours** of electrons in 2025 and imported 0.6. A country that calls itself the battery of Southeast Asia spent this year queueing for diesel, and paid for the privilege in a currency it has to earn.⁵

The shock was not evenly felt. The Bank found the richest fifth of Lao households spends about **thirteen times** more on fuel in absolute terms than the poorest, so the emergency excise relief flowed mostly upward while the poor absorbed the indirect inflation.⁶



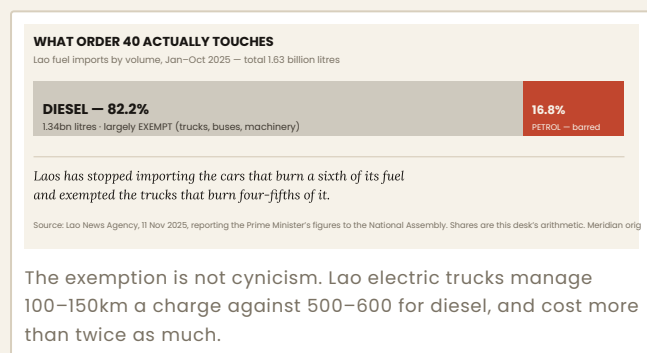
ORDER 40/PM

ENERGY SECURITY

EXPIRES 31 DEC

The levers came in sequence, and the order tells you how a small state under pressure actually governs. First price: excise on premium petrol cut from 40% to 15%, regular from 30% to 15%, diesel from 10% to zero. That cost the treasury **1.6 trillion kip — 0.4% of GDP, about US\$72m** — across three months. The World Bank’s finding on it is blunt: pump prices kept rising anyway, and the eventual fall came from world oil markets, not from Lao tax policy.¹

Then demand, then relative prices, then a fleet mandate, and only then the quantity ban — the step that actually bites, because it hands importers a captive market. So the same notice obliges the commerce ministry to publish a mandated price structure for every class and brand of electric vehicle: ex-factory price, freight, duties, and a **profit ceiling**. Overcharging draws a fine. And all vehicle payments must clear **through the banking system**, which drags the car trade out of cash and into measurable foreign exchange.²



Which is the first thing wrong with reading this as a revolution. Of the 1.63 billion litres Laos imported in the first ten months of 2025, diesel was **1.34 billion — 82.2%**. The May notice exempts passenger-transport vehicles, machinery, project trucks and special-purpose vehicles: precisely the diesel fleet.³

Meanwhile the state is building the thing people plug into, and doing it through everyone at once. In April the national utility signed **27 partners** — electric-truck suppliers, charging developers, fleet operators including the brewery and the post office, and three banks — to build chargers, battery-swap and vehicle

lending. In July the Thai-owned fuel major in Laos agreed to study co-investing in chargers the length of National Road 13, border to border. The Thai oil company is helping build the network that displaces Thai diesel.⁴

“This bond is proof that green finance works in Laos.”

The electricity itself is not free, and the utility’s own book is tighter than the export headline suggests. It traded **19,298 gigawatt-hours** in 2025, up 3%, across 107 generation sources and 4,962 megawatts of capacity; domestic sales plus exports came to **17,828 GWh**, up only 2.4%. It is fast-tracking a new dam due in 2027 and **830 megawatts** of solar explicitly “to secure power supply”, while restructuring debt and renegotiating generation prices. Laos still imports electricity in the dry season — so at the margin, electrified transport may substitute Thai diesel for Thai electrons.⁶

The control is tightening alongside the build-out, in a way that will be familiar to anyone who has watched a state discover a new category. Since July, home chargers require government approval; public stations need construction permits, safety inspection and an approved location — a mall, a transport hub or an existing filling station. The state fuel company, meanwhile, is converting its own forecourts into what it calls modern energy service centres, dual-standard, carrying both the European plug and China’s.⁷

And in September a ride-hailing app issued the country’s first green bond — **US\$997,700** on the Lao Securities Exchange, anchored by a Singapore-headquartered development financier, to add fifteen charging stations. That company already runs the largest charging network in Laos, across all eighteen provinces, and keeps about **95%** of its own fleet electric. The state set the policy; a taxi app built the infrastructure.⁵

SOURCES 1 World Bank, *Lao PDR Economic Monitor*, June 2026, box 1, read from the downloaded PDF, for the excise rates before and after, the fiscal cost in kip and dollars and the finding on what actually moved pump prices. A Lao English-language report of 26 June 2026 gives a different pre-cut rate for regular petrol and records a partial restoration of duties in late June; the Bank’s figures are preferred for the headline and the restoration is noted. 2 The 12 May 2026 notice of the Prime Minister’s Office, as reported by two Lao and regional outlets and in the Lao-language original, all read at source; the mandated price structure, the profit ceiling and the banking-system requirement are its own provisions. 3 Volumes from the Lao News Agency’s report of 11 November 2025 on the prime minister’s figures to the National Assembly, read at source; the percentage shares are this desk’s arithmetic on those volumes, not published figures. Exemption classes from the notice at note 2. Truck range and cost from a Vientiane Times report of 15 April 2026. 4 The April signing and its 27 partners from the Vientiane Times via Asia News Network, 15 April 2026; the Road 13 charging agreement from a Lao English-language report of 8 July 2026, which is marked as sponsored content and is treated here as a record of the signing only. 5 The green bond’s size, anchor investor and purpose from the development financier’s own release of 4 September 2026 and a Vientiane Times report of 7 September, both read at source. Station counts for this company differ between sources by a few units and a range is not asserted. The quoted line is its chief executive’s. 6 The utility’s annual review of 20 February 2026 as reported by a Lao English-language outlet on 23 February, read at source, for the traded and domestic volumes, the generation count and capacity, the solar programme and the quoted purpose. 7 The permit regime from a Vietnamese state agency’s report of the national public works and transport meeting, 13 May 2026; the forecourt conversion from the state fuel company and utility’s memorandum of 24 July 2026 as reported by regional press. Both read at source.

Now the part that should give a Singapore reader pause, because it is where the policy stops being clever. The state is herding its citizens onto a fuel whose price it has just raised. Lao electricity was up **91.5% year on year** in July; the housing, water, electricity and gas basket was up **30.7%** in September, the largest category rise in the index. A household using twenty-five kilowatt-hours saw its bill roughly double between January and July last year under a tariff schedule that keeps climbing to 2029. In September the state conceded a **VAT exemption on the first 300 kilowatt-hours** — subsidising the very fuel it is pushing people towards.¹

So the gain is real and it accrues somewhere specific. Cutting the fuel bill protects **reserves**, which stood at **US\$4.3bn** in April, 3.8 months of imports, against debt service running at **13% of GDP** this year. The kip held: down about 3% against the dollar in May on February, 2% year on year, which for a shock of this size is the dog that did not bark. That is a central-bank victory. It is not a kitchen-table one. Electrification as import substitution redistributes upward, from the household to the sovereign balance sheet — and the World Bank's own distributional finding sharpens it, since the richest fifth spends about **thirteen times** more on fuel in absolute terms, so the emergency tax relief went mostly to them.²

“Stability remains fragile, especially after the recent oil shock.”

There is also a dependency question that answers itself. Laos has escaped a 97.5% reliance on Thai refineries by acquiring one on Chinese cars, batteries and plugs — the state fuel company's chargers will carry China's standard alongside Europe's. Chinese electric-vehicle exports to the region hit **US\$1.2bn in a single month** in June. One trade outlet's verdict is the sharpest anywhere: Laos **“didn't win over car buyers. It removed the alternative.”**³

Treat the Lao numbers carefully, because the government does. The transport ministry says the country has not registered electric vehicles separately or standardised their plates, which **“makes accurate vehicle statistics difficult”** — so the 14,466 figure in circulation is one the issuing ministry will not stand behind. Charging-station counts from four credible sources cannot all be true at once, and the 2030 target is variously 150, 500, or 1,000 to 1,500.⁴

Why it matters here. Singapore sits on both sides of the exact trade Order 40 is trying to rewire: it buys Lao electrons through the four-nation power-integration project, its first ever cross-border electricity import, and it also sold Laos fuel — **1.22%** of Lao imports by the prime minister's own accounting. Every electron Laos burns at home is one the regional grid cannot buy, at a moment when the energy authority is seeking up to **4GW** of low-carbon imports by 2035. The Lao domestic switch and the ASEAN power grid are competing claims on the same reservoirs. And the Singapore-headquartered financier that anchored that green bond is, physically, why a Lao taxi app has chargers in eighteen provinces.⁵

Which leaves the question nobody has reported. The import suspension **expires on 31 December** — in twelve weeks. Nothing has been published about whether it will be extended, made permanent, or quietly allowed to lapse. A new prime minister took office on **5 October**, inheriting the decision along with a growth target he has already conceded will be missed. If it lapses, the experiment ends as a nine-month emergency measure. If it holds, a landlocked country of seven million will have run the first real-world test of electrification as monetary policy — and the rest of the region's small net fuel importers will have a sequence to copy: cut the excise, ration the demand, tilt the prices, mandate the fleets, shut the border, cap the margin, and let development finance build the chargers. Either way the answer arrives before the Financial Times writes it up.⁶

SOURCES 1 Electricity and category inflation from two Lao English-language reports of 11 and 29 September 2026, citing the finance ministry, read at source; the household bill examples and the 2025–2029 tariff schedule from a report of 18 July 2025; the VAT exemption from the September report. 2 Reserves, import cover, the currency moves and the distributional finding from the World Bank's *Lao PDR Economic Monitor*, June 2026, read from the downloaded PDF; the debt-service figure from the Bank's press release of 9 July 2026. The pull quote is the Bank's country manager, in that release. 3 Charging standards from the state fuel company and utility's memorandum of 24 July 2026 as reported by regional press; the regional export figure and the quoted verdict from a specialist trade outlet of 22 July 2026, read at source. 4 The ministry's own admission, reported via a Vietnamese state agency on 13 May 2026, read at source; the conflicting station counts and targets are drawn from four separate published sources and are described rather than reconciled. One Lao report of 6 October 2026 carries revenue and investment figures that are near-certainly unit errors by three orders of magnitude; nothing from it is used here except growth, inflation and trade. 5 The power-integration project's phases from a Singapore ministerial written reply of 2 August 2022 and a 2024 joint release by the energy authority and the operator, both read at source; the 1.22% share from the Lao prime minister's figures at note 1 on [p21](#); the import tender from the energy authority's standing request for proposals. The current status of the project's second phase was not confirmed and no present-tense claim is made about it. 6 The expiry date is the 12 May notice's own. The new prime minister's appointment and his report to the National Assembly from a Lao English-language report of 6 October 2026, read at source. No reporting exists on what follows the expiry; the absence is the finding.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

How many

Twelve tankers were attacked last week, or nine, or seven, or thirteen. A ground-station network has four and a half thousand members and two hundred and ninety-eight of them switched on. A fork is eighteen-ten rather than eighteen-eight, which the steel industry's own association says means nothing at all. A watch is splash resistant, or three bar, or thirty metres, on three pages published by one company in one week. Ten-year yields have risen by ninety-one per cent real, or ninety-eight, or a hundred, depending where you start the clock.

None of these is a lie, and that is what makes them worth a page.

Every one is a competent party counting carefully and arriving somewhere else, because they are counting slightly different things over slightly different boundaries. The verifier verifies before publishing and lands low; the tracker logs what is reported and lands high. The marketing number is real and inert. The ratio doubles a figure that was never large.

The habit this magazine keeps coming back to is not scepticism, which is cheap, but asking what a number counted and where it stopped. A six-thousand-dollar machine went on sale this week whose decisive specification nobody publishes. A paper put two hundred and seventy million dollars in a headline and meant the price of the flats. Lloyd Nelson had it first, and Deming printed it: the figures that matter most are often the ones nobody has. You still have to manage by them.

Twelve Desks · One World MERIDIAN · No. 126 · 8 October 2026

A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the US Treasury's two daily yield curves and the New York Fed's term-premium workbook, both downloaded as data (p14); the environment agency's own five-o'clock feed this morning (p5); two llama.cpp pull requests and their review threads (p8); a Treasury sanctions notice and a quarterly filing (p4, p7); the SatNOGS network's public interface, queried station by station (p15); the World Bank's Laos monitor, extracted from the PDF (p21); two box-office tables cross-checked against each other (p11); three journal papers read in full (p12, p18); and a venue or promoter page for every dated row (p19). Computed here rather than quoted: the real-yield shares on p14, the diesel share of Lao fuel imports on p22, the station-state tallies on p15 and p17, and the per-piece auction figure on p6. Held, not printed: Iran's seven conditions, unenumerated for a third issue; Singapore prices for four separate products; October's auction results; and regional hotspot counts, unobtainable by six routes. Colophon: set in Lora and Poppins. No reader name appears anywhere in this issue.